OUTLAW

AN ILLUSTRATED WESTERN NOVEL

Dean Carson

The land remembers.

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PROLOGUE

So Long, Partner

The first shot had been a long way off. The second sounded closer. By the third, Eli Catcher had stopped counting.

He ran between trees that were older than the towns on any map he knew, his boots slipping in a deep carpet of red needles. The forest was cool and wet, its light strained through a roof of branches two hundred feet above. Under other circumstances he might have stopped to admire it. He had admired these trees all his life, and had lately come to believe the admiration had cost him more than he knew.

His left shoulder burned. Blood had dried beneath his coat, then started again when he fell crossing a creek. Every breath drew a little fire from somewhere behind his ribs. His pistol felt heavy in his hand, though it had only two rounds left, and the satchel striking his hip might as well have been full of stones.

A horse cried out behind him. Men shouted through the timber.

He knew the voices. That was the worst part. He had met some of those men in clean offices. He had shared their whiskey and, once, their money. Now they were hunting him through the same country they meant to clear.

He made for the low ridge, where fallen logs formed a dark jumble between the trunks. If he could get over it, he could reach the old survey road. He knew the road better than they did. He had helped put it there.

A branch tore at his sleeve. He stumbled, caught himself against the bark of a redwood, and pushed onward. His white hat had nearly come off twice; he dragged it down and ran harder. There was a foolishness to keeping a hat on when a man was fighting for his life. Eli had always possessed a great deal of foolishness.

"ELI!"

The voice came from behind him, from somewhere below the ridge. Familiar. Desperate.

For half a heartbeat he let himself believe it meant rescue.

He turned.

The shot split the stillness. Something struck his chest with a force that stole the ground from under him. He twisted, one boot catching in the fern roots, and went down heavily among the fallen branches. The satchel slid from his hand. He heard his own body strike the earth as though it belonged to somebody else.

His white hat lifted away, rolled once through the air, and settled beside him. Its crown was muddy. The brim was bent where he had sat on it months before, after losing an argument with his horse.

Eli stared up through the boughs. The trees moved slowly against a colorless sky. He wanted to say something—something important, something he should have said years ago—but there was no breath for it.

Two more shots cracked through the forest. One after the other.

Bootsteps came toward him. A man stopped beside the white hat. Eli could see only the lower half of him: mud-dark trousers, worn boots, the familiar shine of a revolver at his hip. The man went to one knee. A hand found Eli's shoulder, then his wrist.

There was a silence long enough for the forest to come back: water moving over stones, a faint wind working through the high branches, a bird calling somewhere no one would ever see.

“So long, Partner,” the man said.

The words were so quiet that the trees seemed to have spoken them.

Then the footsteps moved away, and Eli Catcher lay alone beneath the redwoods.

CHAPTER 1

One Week Ago

A crow stood on the face of a freshly cut redwood and regarded the forest with the severe attention of a judge. The stump was broad enough to seat a family at dinner. Pale shavings lay around it in damp curls, and a slow ribbon of sap had begun to bleed down the side. The tree that had once occupied the space was gone. Its absence made the other trees look taller, lonelier, as though some part of a conversation had abruptly ended.

A twig snapped behind the crow. It took flight with a disagreeable cry.

Eli Catcher pushed through the ferns where the bird had been. He was a broad-shouldered man made narrow by age and bad habits, with a gray beard that took no interest in staying trimmed. His coat had once been brown. His hat was white in the way that an old bedsheet is white if a man holds it

far enough from the light. He stepped up to the stump and set a palm upon it.

“Those bastards,” he said. “Another red cut down for some rich pig's new bannister. Or spa room, I'll bet ya.”

He removed his hat and looked at the bright ring of wood. There were hundreds of years in the thing. His own life, which often felt too long, wouldn't have filled one of its smaller scars.

“Hey, Dean! You reckon they'll blame it on the Indians, or that new railway by Carson's Passage?”

A second man came through the trees. Dean Peters was younger by at least twenty years, dark-haired and lean, with a black hat he kept much cleaner than his boots. He wore his revolver low on his right hip, and he possessed an expression that suggested he was always halfway through considering a joke. It was not an expression that had endeared him to sheriffs.

“Ever think,” Dean said, circling the stump, “that maybe some fella like you or me was just down on his luck? Needed a place to hide, cut down the biggest tree he could see?”

Eli studied him. “If you or I was building a hideout, we'd know to use pine. I'd sooner sleep in a ditch than break my back hauling one of these.”

Dean considered that. “You already sleep in ditches.”

“Not by choice.”

“Last Thursday looked like a choice.”

“That was tactical concealment.”

“That was whiskey.”

Eli let out a bark of laughter, and for a few moments the clearing was ordinary again. Two friends, a muddy trail, the morning sun trying to work through the coastal fog. Dean had found, in the two years since they first met, that Eli could make most troubles seem smaller by insulting them. He had also learned that Eli was a remarkably poor judge of which troubles were safe to insult.

They went downhill along a deer track that widened into a torn ribbon of mud. The further they descended, the more light leaked into the timber. At first Dean mistook it for a natural clearing. Then he saw the first neat line of stumps.

There were dozens. Trees so large that three men could not have reached around their trunks had been felled, stripped and dragged away. The ground was gouged by heavy wagons. An abandoned length of chain lay buried in a pool of brown water. Above them, the surviving crowns swayed in the sudden wind.

“Ahh, hell!” Eli shouted. “Now look at this!”

Dean stopped beside him. It was not merely the number of trees that troubled him. The work had been done systematically. Survey stakes showed where the next row would fall. The clearing ran toward the hills in a straight, deliberate line.

“This weren't some fella down on his luck,” Eli said. “And it weren't no Indians. It's that damn railway company.”

He tore off his hat and hurled it into the mud. His satchel followed. Dean watched both go, then watched Eli stand breathing hard. The old man had been angry at logging before, but this was something worse. There was recognition in his face.

“We ought to do something,” Dean said. “Can't just let 'em tear the whole country down.”

Eli looked at the distant stakes. “They'd hang us, son. Sure, I'm willing to die for this land, these trees, the life we live. I don't pretend otherwise. But you're a young man. You don't

need to be wrapped up in trouble just because I shot some fool over a woman."

Dean nodded solemnly. "An ugly woman, too."

Eli turned his head slowly.

"What?" Dean asked.

The silence lasted long enough for a woodpecker to resume hammering somewhere behind them. Dean's smile began to buckle.

"Eli?"

The old cowboy lunged.

Dean managed one astonished yelp before both men went over the edge of the embankment. They slid on wet leaves, struck a dead branch hard enough to splinter it, and rolled down through loose earth with their limbs hopelessly entangled. Dean tried to catch a sapling. Eli caught Dean instead. They gathered speed.

"YOU OLD—"

The slope ended in the middle of a logging camp.

Four men were waking beside the remains of a fire. One was on his feet, reaching for an axe beside a table. A second had been sleeping against a cedar and was scrambling toward a tent some thirty feet off, where the stock of a hunting rifle leaned out of an open flap. The other two sat up and reached for their holsters.

Dean came off the hillside in a roll and found his feet by luck more than skill. Eli landed in a heap, bellowed about his knee, and stood with mud down the side of his face. Both drew their revolvers.

"Drop the chopper!" Eli yelled at the man with the axe.

The axeman stopped. His fingers opened. Steel struck dirt.

Dean saw the rifleman reaching the tent. He fired once, tearing up the soil near the man's boot. "Leave it!" he shouted. The fellow kept going. Dean fired again, hitting his thigh. The man stumbled but reached for the rifle. Dean fired a third time. The rifleman fell into the tent flap and did not rise.

The two men beside the fire drew and began firing almost together.

"Look out!" Eli shouted.

Dean went behind a stack of split logs as a bullet broke a tin cup above his head. Eli threw himself behind a wagon wheel and landed on the same knee he had been complaining about. The air filled with smoke and the rough explosions of gunfire. A kettle toppled from its hook. Someone swore. Somebody else screamed about reloading.

Dean ducked under the woodpile and looked across the camp. Eli was peering over the wagon wheel. Their eyes met. Two idiots, Dean thought, who had set out to look at trees and managed to get four men shooting at them before breakfast.

Eli gave a small nod.

Dean nodded back.

They rose and fired. Dean hit the nearest gunman as he tried to break toward the horses. Eli put a round into the other, who turned and fell against a crate. The shots stopped, leaving only the ringing in Dean's ears and the dry crackle of the old fire.

For several seconds neither moved. The axeman lay facedown near the fire where he had dropped to avoid the shooting. Eli watched him from behind the wheel.

“Stay right there,” Eli said.

The man nodded shakily, then turned his head toward a revolver that had landed near the stones. Dean saw him considering it.

“Don't,” Dean warned.

The axeman made a sudden grab. Eli fired once. He did not miss.

The forest went still.

Dean counted the bodies, though there was no need. He could smell scorched powder over the wet ground and the sharper, metallic smell that followed. The dead were not wearing uniforms. One had a wedding band, plainly visible against his dirt-dark hand. Another looked scarcely older than Dean. Their belonging to the railroad would not make them less dead. He had understood that in other fights; there was always a difference between understanding it later and understanding it now.

Eli emerged from cover with his revolver lowered.

Neither man spoke for a long moment. Dean suddenly remembered what had brought them down the hillside, and some absurd part of him wanted to laugh. He did not.

“Truce?” Dean asked at last.

Eli looked at his mud-soaked hat, at the bodies, and then at Dean. “Truce.”

They shook hands. It was a ridiculous gesture beside a ruined camp, but Dean held on a moment longer than the joke required. Eli's fingers were trembling. So were his own.

“Now,” Eli said, retrieving his hat, “let's get the hell out of here.”

They found their horses up the slope and rode hard for the old road. Behind them, smoke rose through the broken trees. Neither spoke of the four men. Dean thought about the wedding band and kept his eyes on the trail.

By noon they could see Hamilton in the valley, its roofs catching the weak sunshine, and Eli was humming as though a man might outride memory with sufficient determination.

Dean knew better. He had tried it himself.

CHAPTER 2

Hamilton

Hamilton was a town of promises, most of them nailed above doors. The general store promised fair prices. The saloon promised good company. The coach office promised safe passage over roads that looked capable of killing a mule in dry weather. The railway station, still smelling of new lumber, promised the future in large painted letters. Hamilton itself promised very little beyond mud.

The street ran between two rows of weathered buildings under a sky the color of river stone. Cattle drifted past the butcher's yard. A blacksmith hammered a shoe into shape. Somewhere near the station a steam engine shrieked like an animal being badly mistreated.

Eli steered his horse toward the general store. “First thing,” he announced, “is food. Second thing's tobacco. Third thing's finding a place nobody's likely to ask us difficult questions.”

“Second thing ought to be washing that face,” Dean said.

“Faces don't go hungry.”

“Yours is upsetting mine.”

Eli opened his mouth for an answer, then a young woman burst from the store and called his name.

“Uncle Eli!”

She came down the two steps so fast Dean thought she might clear them entirely. Mary Catcher threw her arms around the old cowboy and nearly pushed him against his horse. Eli gave a wounded groan that was half genuine and half performance.

“Ogh! Course I made it back, hon. But careful, now. Your uncle can hardly walk nowadays.”

Mary pulled away, still holding his sleeves, and inspected him with the impatience of someone who had spent years expecting bad news. She had dark hair pinned loosely at the nape of her neck and eyes that missed very little. She wore a simple dress and a shop apron, both clean enough to suggest she had already done more work that morning than Eli intended to do all week.

“You said you'd be back Sunday,” she told him.

“Was Sunday a week ago?”

“Two.”

“Then I'm early for next Sunday.”

Mary made a face. Eli kissed the top of her head and turned her toward Dean.

“And this, Mary, is my partner in crime. Dean Peters. Dean, my niece, Mary Catcher.”

Dean removed his hat. Mary looked at him, then at the well-kept revolver on his belt.

“My, my,” she said. “You must be some gunslinger if my uncle keeps you around.”

Dean had faced angry horses, drunken miners and the occasional man pointing a shotgun at his stomach. None of those situations had emptied his mind so thoroughly.

“You look like quite the killer yourself,” he said.

The sentence hung between them.

Mary's eyebrows rose. Dean wished the ground would swallow him, but Hamilton's mud, cruelly, remained firm.

Eli leaned toward his niece. “I think that was supposed to be a compliment.”

The old man exploded into laughter. He slapped his knee, choked, coughed, and laughed again. Mary bit the inside of her cheek. Dean put his hat back on, looked from one face to the other, and walked away without a word.

“Good to meet you too!” Mary called after him, finally laughing.

Dean lifted a hand but refused to turn around.

He passed the saloon. Two women sat on the stoop, smoking cigars and watching the town like spectators at a cheap theater. One called, “Hey, pretty boy! Why don't you come inside?”

He very nearly did. Then shouting from the sheriff's office crossed the street.

A heavyset man in a fitted suit stood on the boardwalk, red-faced and furious. Beside him was a long, narrow fellow who looked as though somebody had stretched a poor idea too far. Both wore expensive boots now covered in Hamilton mud. Facing them was Sheriff Derrick McClean, a square-jawed lawman with weathered hands and the tired expression of a man constantly being asked to choose between bad decisions.

“You sons of whores are killing our land!” the heavy man shouted, though who exactly he meant by our was not clear.

Derrick said something too quiet to carry. The heavy man spat toward the steps and stalked away with his companion.

Dean crossed the street. “Who were Porky and Slim over there?”

Derrick regarded him with undisguised suspicion. “What do you want?”

“An answer, mostly.”

“Then ask somebody interested.”

Before Dean could reply, the narrow man stopped beside a newspaper boy standing near the station road. Neil was fifteen if that, painfully thin under a cap two sizes too large. He held out a stack of papers and offered one. The man shoved the stack aside. Pages scattered through the mud.

“Please, mister,” Neil said, bending to gather them. “Just take a paper. Take one for each of you. Hell, take the lot—”

The narrow man struck him. Neil fell back against the station fence.

Dean was moving before he made the decision.

“What the hell are you doing, little man?” he demanded, stepping between the boy and the man's raised fist. “He's half your age and twice the man you are.”

The man stared at him, jaw working. Dean pointed a finger close enough to see the broken veins in his opponent's nose.

“You ought to try hitting somebody your own size.”

“Gladly,” said the larger man from behind.

Dean managed to turn his head before the big fellow hit him like a runaway wagon. Both men went down into the street. Dean struck the ground hard; then the beer bottle came down on his temple, and the world folded into a bright, soundless point.

The next thing he knew, nobody was there. This was because, for several minutes, Dean knew nothing at all.

Derrick drew and shouted for the men to get back. The larger one—Doug Barlow—rose with broken glass in his hand. The narrow one, Slim Kern, spread his arms in a false show of innocence.

“Count your blessings, McClean,” Doug said as they backed toward the station. “Heh-heh.”

Derrick ignored him. He was kneeling in the mud beside the younger cowboy, trying to decide whether the blood on the ground was more alarming than the way Dean's eyes had rolled back.

“Doctor!” he shouted. “Somebody fetch Spalding! Now!”

Across the street, Eli was arguing over the cost of oats.

“Two dollars?” he asked the storekeeper. “Two whole dollars? A year ago you'd have got me rain dancing butt-naked in the square for two dollars!”

The storekeeper, who had begun to suspect Eli was taking the argument personally, looked toward Mary for help. She put down two silver dollars.

“Uncle. Stop.”

“I'm merely discussing the unreasonable price of life.”

“You're holding up the line.”

“There ain't a line.”

“There will be if you keep talking.”

Mary tapped his shoulder with a closed fist. Eli grinned at her and stuffed the oats, coffee and tobacco into a sack. He had also bought a blank journal, an absurd purchase for a man who read slowly and treated writing as a private enemy. Mary noticed it and said nothing. Eli slipped it beneath his coat.

Doctor Richard Spalding burst in, nearly knocking a shelf of tins sideways. He was a tall, anxious man whose spectacles had been repaired with wire. He started pulling bandages from the shelves.

“Cloth,” he said. “Clean cloth. Whiskey, if you've got it. Carbolic, and quickly. I've a young man with a head wound—”

Mary was already moving. Eli threw the supplies into the shopkeeper's sack and followed. Richard hurried through the door. They went down the street together, past the gathering spectators, toward the surgery.

Eli saw the black hat lying beside Neil's fallen papers.

He stopped so suddenly Mary nearly ran into him.

“Uncle?”

It was Dean's hat. A moment earlier he had been wondering where the boy had gone. Now the sight of the familiar black felt on the ground drew all the blood from his face.

He seized Mary's hand and ran.

They tore into the doctor's office, shoved past a startled patient, and burst into the treatment room. Dean was sitting upright on the table with a bandage around his head, blinking as though the room had become oddly arranged. He had regained consciousness after Richard first examined him and was protesting that the doctor had ruined a perfectly good shirt.

Dean looked up as Eli came in, breathless, eyes wide.

“Were they out of cigars?” he asked.

For a moment nobody spoke. Richard stood holding a bottle of antiseptic. Mary was half crying, half furious. Eli stared at the patient he had imagined dead.

Then Eli began to laugh. It was not a sensible laugh. It was the wild, helpless sound of a man who had taken a terrible fright and had nowhere else to put it. Mary joined in. Richard made an exasperated noise and then gave way. Dean watched them all, bewildered.

“What's funny?” he asked. “I was serious.”

By evening, Dean had convinced Richard he was fit to drink, despite the doctor's clear explanation that this was an unusually foolish idea. The five of them met at the saloon:

Dean, Eli, Mary, Derrick, and the physician who was beginning to regret every professional decision that had brought him to Hamilton.

A fiddler found a tune worth playing. Somebody produced a banjo. The night rose in volume until the bar became a churn of boots, skirts and bad dancing. Eli insisted he knew a jig from a county fair forty years ago. He demonstrated it with such enthusiasm that he knocked over a chair and nearly broke the arm Derrick had once threatened to arrest him for using.

Mary danced with the butcher's wife, then with Neil, who turned bright red when she took his hands. Dean stood near the bar, nursing a drink and his wounded pride. He watched her laugh. Twice he considered asking her to dance. Twice Eli caught him looking and made a face so obscene that Dean nearly threw his glass.

The old man's pleasure in humiliating him, Dean realized, came from genuine affection. It was a terrible discovery.

When the music slowed and the saloon grew hot with lamplight, Eli came to Dean and clapped him on the shoulder.

“Come on. Air.”

Out back, they stood beside the fence with their beer bottles in one hand, relieving themselves into the dark with the other. The night smelled of wet wood and coal smoke. From somewhere beyond the roofs came a low, distant whistle.

“I overheard some good ol' boys talking about Jackson Ward Railway,” Eli said. “Sounds like the whole affair's run by one bigwig asshole named Calvin H. Douberville. They've got offices east of here. Whole yard full of oil-backed, no-good pigs.”

Dean glanced across. “What's that got to do with us?”

“Well, since we killed some of their boys, and they're killing our country, I'd say it's got everything to do with us.”

“You sure those boys were theirs?”

Eli finished his beer. “Sure enough.”

Dean was quiet. He thought of the man with the wedding ring.

Eli put a hand on his shoulder. “Rest tonight. Tomorrow I'll show you what I'm talking about.”

He returned inside, leaving Dean beneath a strip of clear sky between the roofs. A few stars showed through the smoke. Dean listened to the sound of Mary's laugh coming through the saloon wall and remembered Eli standing over that fresh-cut stump, looking at something far beyond the wood.

“Hope you know what you're doing, old man,” he said.

He put out his cigarette and went back inside.

CHAPTER 3

A Horse Worth Stealing

Two years before the trouble in Hamilton, Dean Peters had been hungry enough to consider eating the horse he was supposed to be riding. The animal was a stout bay gelding with a bad disposition and a suspicious white patch above one eye. Dean had acquired it from a rancher who owed him forty dollars, a debt the rancher claimed existed only in Dean's imagination.

The gelding was not fast. It was not particularly obedient. It had, however, carried Dean across three counties without demanding payment, which made it better company than most people he had met.

They stopped outside a saloon in a town called Pike's Crossing, where Dean had heard a card game might offer him a chance to improve his circumstances. He tied the horse to the rail, told it not to go anywhere, and went inside to lose the last of his money.

When he emerged an hour later, the horse was gone.

In its place stood a man in a dirty white hat drinking from a bottle. He leaned against the hitching rail with the pleased expression of a person who has discovered a joke at somebody else's expense.

“Looking for something?” the man asked.

“My horse.”

“Oh.” The stranger looked toward the stables. “That was your horse?”

“Yes.”

“Funny. Looks an awful lot like mine.”

Dean stepped closer. “Where is it?”

“Stable.”

“Why?”

“Because I own it.”

Dean stared. “I won that horse off a rancher.”

The man took another drink. “Did you, now? Rancher name of Gus Webb?”

“Maybe.”

“Got a habit of borrowing things that don't belong to him?”

“Maybe.”

“Then you won my horse off the man who stole it.”

Dean considered the logic and found it offensive. “And who the hell are you?”

“Eli Catcher.” He tipped his hat. “Pleasure.”

Dean removed his own hat and struck the old man in the face with it. Eli dropped the bottle, swore, and tackled him into the street. They rolled through a puddle while a small crowd gathered to enjoy the spectacle. Neither was fighting as well as he imagined. Dean was younger and quicker; Eli was heavier and considerably more experienced at using a knee in the least courteous ways.

After several minutes the sheriff came out of the saloon, took one look at them, and announced that both would be spending the night in jail unless they settled the matter privately. Eli, who had a longstanding dislike of any room that locked from the outside, immediately offered a compromise.

“We'll play for him,” he said.

Dean wiped blood from his lip. “Play what?”

“Cards.”

“I haven't any money.”

“Neither have I. That's why we're playing for a horse.”

They went back inside. A card game began beneath a lamp so dim neither man could see the other's sleeves properly. Eli won the first hand, Dean the second. After four hands the dealer discovered that both had been cheating. Eli accused Dean of marking the deck; Dean accused Eli of hiding an ace in his boot. The dealer, deciding his saloon had endured enough, threw them both into the street.

They stood beside the stable, muddy and penniless, considering the terrible injustice of it all.

“Who owns the horse?” Dean asked.

Eli scratched his beard. “I suppose we both do.”

“That's absurd.”

“Then you buy my half.”

“With what?”

“You got a gun?”

“I ain't selling my gun.”

“Then we share the animal until we find something better to argue about.”

Dean looked at the gelding, who was watching them from the stall with a look of profound disappointment.

“Fine,” he said. “But I ride in front.”

Eli laughed. “Son, there's hardly room for me in front of your mouth.”

They left Pike's Crossing together the next morning, taking turns riding and walking. The first day they barely spoke. On the second they argued about the shortest route to the coast. On the third they fell in with a traveler whose wagon had broken an axle, and Eli insisted they stop to help. Dean complained about the delay but spent the afternoon under the wagon with a length of iron, cursing every bolt. The traveler paid them with supper and a place to sleep.

By the end of the week they had discovered they were both wanted in different places, both poor judges of honest employment, and both possessed a habit of making trouble worse by refusing to back down. Eli had also learned that Dean carried a faded photograph of a woman in his pocket and never looked at it in company. Dean had learned that Eli grew quiet when a train passed, as if he were listening for something nobody else could hear.

They were different men, but they recognized the same loneliness in one another. They never spoke about it. Instead they worked together, fought together, and slowly became the sort of companions who could tell what the other intended by a glance across a room.

Months later, after they had traded the bay gelding for two serviceable horses, Dean asked Eli whether he had really owned the animal in Pike's Crossing.

Eli considered the question. “Of course.”

“Got proof?”

“Had a bill of sale somewhere.”

“Did you?”

“Maybe.”

Dean shook his head. “You old thief.”

Eli grinned. “World's best horse thief, son. Don't you forget it.”

Dean had never forgotten. In later years, whenever Eli embarrassed him in front of Mary, he liked to remind the old man that their friendship had begun with an act of theft. Eli would say it began with Dean trying to steal the same horse twice. Their disagreement became a small private piece of the world, a story they could tell without agreeing how it ended.

And in Hamilton, after a night of music and beer and laughter, Dean went to sleep without knowing how few mornings he had left to hear it again.

CHAPTER 4

The Plan

Dean woke to the impression that an entire brass band had taken rooms behind his eyes. He lay on the saloon's narrow bed in one boot and yesterday's shirt, his hat drawn over his face, while a rooster somewhere outside declared war on the morning.

A knock came from the door. Before he could answer, it opened.

“Rise and shine, sunshine.”

Eli stood with two cups of coffee, looking obscenely cheerful. Dean pulled the hat from his eyes.

“Christ. Your face is a cruel thing to wake up to.”

“Funny. Your mother said the same.”

Dean threw his spare boot. Eli dodged; coffee went across the floorboards.

“Damn you! That costs money!”

“So do doors,” Dean muttered.

Eli settled at the little table and unfolded two maps. They were nearly the size of the tabletop, one worn and stained, the other crisp and bearing the blue ink of the Jackson Ward Railway survey office. Dean dragged himself upright when he saw the difference. The older line followed the natural passage between the hills. The new one cut south and west through a long band of old growth and crossed land marked RED WILLOW.

“Why change it?” he asked.

“That's what I'd like to know.” Eli pointed with a callused finger. “They take the longer way round the hills, pay for a thousand acres of clearing, build two extra bridges. Don't sound like a man trying to save a dollar.”

“Gold?”

“Maybe timber. Coal. Rights below the ground. Maybe a combination worth more than all of Hamilton.”

Dean traced the line to a cluster of red marks. “What are those?”

“Places bad things have happened. Blackwater Creek. Carson's Gorge. Red Willow.”

“Ain't the gorge where them surveyors died?”

“Officially. Wagon accident.” Eli's mouth tightened. “Funny how the bad luck keeps falling on folks who won't sell.”

Dean looked up. “How'd you get these maps?”

“Old friends.”

“That's not an answer.”

“It's the one you got.”

Mary appeared in the doorway carrying a basket of bread and eggs. Dean stood at once, which caused his head to throb and one bare foot to catch his discarded boot. He windmilled a hand and sat back down hard.

Mary regarded him with amused sympathy. “I heard you were feeling better.”

“Never better,” Dean managed.

Eli took a piece of bread. “He's been practicing that line since dawn.”

Mary set the basket down and glanced at the maps, but Eli folded them before she could see more than their edges. She noticed. Dean noticed that she noticed. The old man had become a collection of little evasions.

Later, on a ridge east of town, those evasions grew harder to ignore.

A railway worksite occupied the valley below. Trees lay in great stripped rows; enormous horses hauled their trunks toward a sawpit. Men with hammers moved along a timber trestle that rose out of the muddy ground and disappeared among the hills. A small locomotive edged along a length of new track, pushing flatcars stacked with ties. Its whistle rolled over the clearing with a sound like the country complaining.

Armed guards patrolled the perimeter. Beyond the construction yards stood a fenced collection of long buildings. Dean borrowed Eli's field glasses and saw people moving behind the wire and timber: an old woman carrying a bucket, a boy no older than Neil, a man with a bandaged arm. A guard knocked the man's bucket from his hands and shoved him back from the gate.

“Those aren't laborers,” Dean said.

“No.”

“Who are they?”

“Families who used to live where that track's going.”

The answer came too quickly. Dean lowered the glasses. Eli was watching the compound without surprise.

“You've been here before.”

Eli took a long time to answer. “Not lately.”

A shot cracked from beyond the fence. A woman screamed. Dean reached for his pistol, though the guards below were a hundred yards away and too numerous to count.

Eli caught his wrist. “Not here.”

“They're shooting at people.”

“I heard.”

“Then get off me.”

“We ride down there now, we'll be dead in five minutes, and they'll still have them families. That's not courage. That's wasting two lives to make a point.”

Dean knew he was right and hated him for it. He let go of the pistol. Together they watched smoke push across the clearing, gray against the brutal geometry of the stumps.

When they rode away, Dean's anger traveled with him. He asked twice what Eli planned to do and got no useful answer. At last the old man said they were going to visit Red Willow, where Richard knew some families who might talk.

“What families?” Dean asked.

“Ones that have had their homes taken.”

Dean looked back once. The train whistle was still echoing among the hills, long after the train had vanished from sight.

CHAPTER 5

At the Edge of the Yard

There was a road below the ridge that carried construction wagons toward Hamilton. Dean and Eli followed it at a distance until they came to a place where the rails crossed an old cattle track. Workers were gathering at a cook tent beyond the crossing, their lunch pails balanced on their knees. Most wore the exhausted look of men who had been awake before sunrise and would work until after dark.

Dean watched them from behind a stand of alder. “They don't all look like killers.”

“Most of 'em ain't,” Eli said.

“Then why are they guarding people?”

“Most don't know. Some don't want to know. Some get paid not to ask.”

Dean thought about the four men in the camp. “You reckon the fellows we killed worked on this line?”

“Company camp, company axes.”

“That's not what I asked.”

Eli followed his gaze. A foreman was distributing bread at the tent while another man counted names from a paper. One worker had his arm bound in a dirty cloth. Another gave half his lunch to a boy who looked too young for the work. Eli knew such men. He had been one himself, taking whatever labor could be found because a horse could not be fed on pride.

“Maybe some knew,” he said. “Maybe some didn't.”

Dean was quiet. He wanted the world to divide itself into men who deserved a bullet and men who didn't. The world had a poor opinion of his preference.

They crossed the road after the workers went back to the timber. At a little shack near the tracks they found an old woman selling coffee and pies through a window. Eli bought two slices and complained about the price until she threatened

to close the shutter on his fingers. Dean sat on an upturned crate and ate with more enthusiasm than the food deserved.

The woman introduced herself as Mrs. Avery. Her husband had been a track foreman before an accident crushed his leg. Jackson Ward had sent a letter expressing regret and a bill for the cost of his last week's lodging. Since then she had sold food to the men who could pay and given it to those who couldn't.

“Folks in Hamilton tell me the railway's bringing prosperity,” Dean said.

Mrs. Avery looked at her shack, at the patched roof and the stove that smoked whenever it rained. “Somebody's getting prosperous. They ain't told me when it's my turn.”

Eli laughed, but the sound lacked its usual force. The woman noticed his face and studied him for a moment.

“You're the survey fellow,” she said.

Eli stopped chewing. “Used to be.”

“I remember you. Came through three summers ago with a red-haired clerk. You told my husband the new grade would run through the western valley.”

“Things changed.”

“Sure did. They took the old road, too. Put up a gate and called it company land. I had to pay a fee to bring flour into my own yard.”

Dean turned toward Eli. The old man stared into his coffee, looking as though he'd discovered something unpleasant at the bottom. Mrs. Avery continued working the stove and did not seem to notice.

“I'm told the boss is coming to town next week,” she said. “Big supper. Fine speeches. Bet he'll tell 'em the same thing he told my husband.”

“What's that?” Dean asked.

“Be patient. It'll all be better when the line's finished.”

She cut him another piece of pie. “My husband used to say patience was the only thing a poor man could afford to give away.”

They left after paying, and Dean walked his horse along the roadside for a while. Eli followed without urging conversation. At a bend they passed a low fence where a group of railway

laborers had stopped to look at a dead mule. The foreman was arguing about how to move it before the next wagon came. Life at the edge of the yard proceeded with all the ordinary misery of work, and the grand promise painted on the station seemed to belong to another country.

Dean looked at the stamped company initials on a fence post. “We go down there shooting,” he said, “we'll kill men like that woman’s husband.”

“Maybe,” Eli admitted.

“And the man responsible will have a clean pair of gloves and a train ticket east.”

Eli stopped and looked at him. It was the first time Dean had spoken of the problem as something larger than a fair fight.

“Then we ought to find the man who pays for it,” Eli said.

Dean nodded. “And the papers he used.”

The old cowboy's face changed almost imperceptibly. Dean noticed, as he had been noticing more and more, and chose not to ask. The question would come soon enough. For now they turned toward Hamilton, carrying their new knowledge with them as carefully as their loaded revolvers.

CHAPTER 6

Red Willow

Eli drove the supply wagon with one hand and ate an apple with the other. Dean sat beside him, bracing his boots against the footboard and regarding every turn as a fresh personal insult. In the rear, Mary held a box of medicine steady while Doctor Spalding tried to inventory bottles that rattled with every rut.

“You see that pothole?” Dean asked.

“Which one?”

“The hole we just drove through.”

“Must not have been much of one. Wagon's still here.”

A moment later the front wheel struck a stone. Dean rose six inches off the seat and landed with a curse. Richard gave an injured cry from the back.

“I'm driving home,” Dean announced.

Eli took another bite. “Thought you were afraid of hard work.”

Mary leaned forward between them. “Would both of you shut up long enough to keep us alive?”

The men fell silent. Dean counted four heartbeats before Eli whispered, “She's got your manners.”

The wagon slowed as they entered the settlement. No one made a joke after that.

The road passed between ruined houses. Some had burned to their foundations; others stood hollow, their windows black. A child's chair lay in a patch of wet ash. Near the creek, survivors had stretched canvas over wagon frames and built hearths from broken stones. They had repaired what they could with hands and tools, and there was a stubborn order to the camp that made the destruction seem more deliberate.

A woman carrying a hunting rifle came toward them. She was younger than Eli had expected, with a red scarf tied at her throat and a way of standing that did not invite argument. Her name was Mara Wren, and the people behind her listened when she spoke.

“More railway men?” she called.

Mary stood in the wagon. “No. We've brought supplies.”

“That's what the last men said.”

Richard stepped down. “Mara.”

She recognized him. Something in her face eased, but only a little. “Doctor. You're late.”

“I know. There was trouble getting medicine.”

“There's been trouble with everything.” She looked over the wagon, counting the blankets and crates. “Bring it down by the creek. The sick are under the blue canvas.”

The next hours passed quickly. Richard opened a rough surgery near the water. Mary distributed bread, boiling water and clean cloth. Dean was put to work digging a new latrine, which he accepted as proof that kindness was frequently punished. Eli unloaded the wagon, then wandered among the ruined houses with his hat in his hands.

At the edge of an old garden he found a survey stake, blackened by fire. He knew the cut of the wood, the shape of the stamped iron head. There were numbers on it. He cleared away the soot with his thumb, and there, below the measurements, were the initials E. CATCHER and the year 1884.

He had made the mark himself.

A voice came behind him. “You looking for something?”

He covered the letters with dirt before he turned. Dean stood near a fallen fence post, breathing hard from his digging.

“Just walking,” Eli said.

Dean looked at the stake, then at the old man's hand. “All right.”

There were times when Dean could be too clever, and times when he chose not to be. Eli was grateful for the second kind.

That evening Mara gathered them around a small fire. Several of the older residents sat nearby. They spoke about the boundaries as people speak about a road washed away: with exact names, times and the memory of how the place had been before. Some families had lived on that ground for generations. They had negotiated the reservation limits years earlier, and there had been signed agreements. Then railway men arrived with newer documents and new measurements, saying the old boundaries were mistakes.

“First they said they would pay us to move,” Mara told them. “Then they said we had no right to be here at all. When we refused, the fires started.”

Dean watched a young boy coax a thin dog toward the flames. “They blamed that on raiders, I heard.”

“They blamed us,” Mara replied. “Said we'd burned our own houses to frighten settlers.”

“Why would anybody believe that?”

“Because we weren't the ones printing the newspapers.”

Richard, tending a woman nearby, looked up. “I saw gunshot wounds on four bodies after the first fire. The county report called their deaths smoke inhalation.”

Eli's face moved as though he were chewing something bitter.

Mara took a brass tag from her coat. It was scorched, the letters on it uneven but legible: J.W.R., followed by a

warehouse number. “This was found under the floor of the house where my cousin died. Tell me what use it is to a judge who gets paid by the men who made it.”

Dean turned the tag over in his palm. He could feel the heat of the campfire through the metal. “Maybe we need another judge.”

Mara regarded him, measuring whether he meant it. “We've been looking.”

Later, while Richard slept beside his patients and Eli checked the wagon horses, Dean sat with Mary by the creek. The water was dark beneath the moon, and the bank still smelled of smoke after three weeks of rain.

“How'd you meet my uncle?” Mary asked.

Dean was carefully scraping mud from his boot. “He tried to steal my horse.”

She laughed. “Surely not.”

“He did. Said it was his.”

“Was it?”

Dean paused. “That depends who you ask.”

“I'm asking you.”

“Well, I'd borrowed it from a man who owed me money.”

Mary covered her mouth. “Dean.”

“The man insisted the horse belonged to somebody else, but people say all manner of things when you take their horse.”

“And Eli?”

“Eli was the somebody else.”

Mary began laughing properly, the sort of laughter that left her breathless. Dean watched her, surprised to discover that the sound changed the whole creek. He had found her attractive from the moment she called out to Eli in Hamilton. He had not anticipated that he would enjoy being laughed at by her.

She told him about her childhood in Hamilton, about the store, about Aunt Margaret and the years Eli disappeared only to return with outlandish stories and gifts that were always too big or too small. Dean told her only a little about himself. He had been moving for so long that the notion of a permanent childhood felt like something belonging to other people.

Across the fire, Eli watched them. For a moment he smiled with an unguarded tenderness Dean would never have believed him capable of. Then the old man took a folded survey from his coat and looked at his own signature. He could see, in the slant of the pen, the hand of a younger man who had accepted a considerable sum of money for drawing a line through somebody else's home.

He folded it away when Mary looked up.

The creek kept moving in the dark, carrying ash and rainwater toward a sea none of them could see.

CHAPTER 7

Where the River Has Names

Mara Wren had learned to tell the season by the sound of the creek. In spring it rolled loudly over the stones and carried branches down from the mountains. In summer it grew narrow and patient, exposing smooth rocks where the children liked to sit with their feet in the water. Autumn brought leaves and colder mornings. The winter floods sometimes moved the bank itself, and the families who lived beside it knew which fences would hold and which had to be rebuilt.

The railway survey called it Watercourse 17.

Mara had once seen that number on one of the maps the company brought to the council house. She had laughed before she understood the danger. To the men with the maps, the creek was a blue line between two numbered lots. Its springs, pools, fishing places and stories did not appear because they had no box in the ledger. The mapmaker had not bothered to ask whether the land already belonged to someone who could name it better.

That night after the supply wagon left, she sat beneath the blue canvas with Mrs. Talan and her younger brother Jonah. They had a list of missing people spread across the table. The names had been gathered from the families who had not yet returned, the quarry workers who had been moved without notice, and the people taken from the creek settlement after the first fire.

“We're missing the children from the east camp,” Jonah said.

Mrs. Talan adjusted her shawl. “Not all missing. Some with relatives upriver. You must mark the difference.”

Mara nodded and changed the list. The distinction mattered. Every name marked missing created another grief, but every name marked safe carried a responsibility to keep that person safe. They had spent three weeks learning that accurate

records were not merely the concern of businessmen and judges.

A young man called Peter came to the canvas entrance. He had been among the last families driven from the houses nearer the rail line, and he still had a bandage across one hand. “They're offering work at the yard,” he announced. “Cash. Food. A bunk.”

Jonah looked up sharply. “Who?”

“Jackson Ward. A foreman came by the road.”

Mara waited. Peter's face showed what he needed to say before his mouth did.

“My sister's hungry. There's not enough flour in the camp. I can carry ties. I don't have to like the company to take its pay.”

Jonah began to object, but Mara held up a hand. “You're right,” she told Peter. “You don't have to like them. The choice is yours.”

He looked relieved, then uncertain. “You think I shouldn't go.”

“I think the company is offering food because it took yours away. I think you should know that before you decide. And I think the rest of us need to find a way to feed your sister without asking you to risk a place inside their fence.”

He sat at the table while they counted the flour sacks and discussed which families had a little left to share. Mrs. Talan made a list of the children needing extra rations. It was not a dramatic decision. Nobody drew a gun or made a speech. The work took most of the night, and by morning Peter had enough supplies to remain in camp until they could arrange something more lasting.

Mara walked outside after midnight. The moon shone over the burned houses, turning broken rafters silver. She found Jonah standing by the creek, repairing a lantern with a thin piece of wire.

“Does he think I'm angry with him?” she asked.

“He thinks you're angry with everybody.”

“Sometimes I am.”

Jonah smiled faintly. “He knows. He also knows you'll still bring water to his sister.”

They stood listening to the creek. Downstream, where the first bridge had stood, the company had driven a steel stake into the bank. The stake marked the new boundary it intended to enforce. Mara had removed it twice. Each time another had appeared.

“Eli Catcher looked at the old survey marker today,” Jonah said. “I saw him from the wagon.”

Mara turned toward him. “What did he do?”

“Covered it with dirt when the young fellow came near.”

She remembered the old man. He had brought medicine, unloaded supplies without being asked, and removed his hat when she spoke of the dead. There had been guilt in his face, but she had mistaken it for the ordinary shame of a man who arrived after disaster and could do little to help.

“His name was on the map,” she said.

Jonah nodded. “He's the one who signed the line.”

For a moment she wanted to ride straight to Hamilton and ask Eli what price he had put on the creek. Then she looked toward the canvas where the sleeping children lay. There were more useful questions to ask first. Who had ordered the second survey? Who had hired the guards? Who could carry the documents beyond Calvin's reach?

“Don't let him disappear,” she told Jonah. “If he knows what happened, he can tell us.”

“What if he won't?”

“Then we'll find somebody else.”

Mrs. Talan came out with a blanket and laid it over Mara's shoulders. She had known Mara's mother and had seen several generations of argument about the same stretch of land. Her face held the weariness of people who had been required to explain their belonging too often.

“Your father used to stand where you're standing,” she said. “He'd look down at the creek and talk about the water being older than all the papers in the county office.”

Mara smiled. “I remember.”

“He used to say a map was useful for finding your way, but it wasn't a good way to know a place.”

Mara looked toward the dark line of trees. Beyond them, she knew, were the foundations of houses, the graves of grandparents, and paths that had been walked for years before the surveyors arrived. The railway could number the land. It could even seize it for a time. It could not make those memories into somebody else's property.

The next morning Mara called a meeting. She explained what Doctor Spalding and the travelers had brought, what records were still missing, and how testimony could help challenge the removals. She made clear that anyone who spoke would choose which details could be repeated outside the camp. The company had lied using official papers; she would not answer by treating her own people as lines in somebody else's story.

The meeting lasted until noon. Some wanted to leave. Some wanted to confront the guards immediately. Others wanted to wait for a lawyer they had never met. Mara listened to all of them and put the different plans on the table. At last they agreed to assemble statements, prepare for the return of the prisoners and keep the camp supplied as well as they could.

When the people dispersed, Jonah asked if she thought it would be enough.

“No,” Mara said. “But it's something we can do today.”

She went to the creek and watched the water carry a leaf past the old boundary stone. Somewhere downstream were the company's new tracks, and somewhere beyond them a man named Calvin who believed the country existed to be measured and sold.

Mara knew she might never meet him. She also knew he would have to hear her name before she was finished.

CHAPTER 8

The Line on the Map

On the ride home from Red Willow, the wagon made a new sound. Dean said it came from the left wheel and insisted the axle would be in pieces before they reached Hamilton. Eli said it was nothing of the kind and the sound came from Dean's mouth. Mary made them stop so Richard could examine the wheel. The doctor discovered a loose iron collar, repaired it with a length of wire, and informed both men that his medical training had finally been put to its highest purpose.

They laughed. There was relief in the laughter, because Red Willow had made ordinary conversation difficult. The ruins were still fresh in their minds. They had eaten with families who kept their food in rescued flour sacks, and slept beside people who woke at the sound of a horse because horses had brought the men who burned their houses.

Eli watched the road ahead and remembered another morning in the same valley, three years earlier. The memory came with particular clarity. The map had been unrolled on a desk not unlike the little table in the hunting cabin. A man in a tailored coat stood beside it, and a younger Eli Catcher had been proud to be there.

At that time, Eli had been short of money and long on appetite. He could ride a line, take a bearing, estimate a grade and bring back figures a professional engineer could trust. He had worked for ranchers, prospectors and a county road crew. Jackson Ward offered more than any of them paid, in silver and on time. The company clerk had said his knowledge of the country made him valuable. Eli, who had rarely been called valuable to his face, believed him.

Calvin Douberville had not been the president then, but the president had already learned to leave decisions to him. He sat

across the desk from Eli one gray morning in the spring of 1884 and placed a clean map beside the one Eli had made.

“We require a revised survey,” Calvin said. “The current route presents unnecessary complications.”

Eli studied the two drawings. The new line crossed Red Willow ground and reached west to the timber stands. “That's not a small change,” he said.

“No.”

“The old road goes round the ridge. It's solid country.”

“It's longer.”

“Not by much.”

Calvin's pen moved between two valleys. “Longer enough to lose a valuable mineral claim. Longer enough to make our investors impatient. We have reason to believe the reservation boundary on the official map is in error.”

Eli knew the boundary. He had walked parts of it with a county team. He knew the creek and the old cedar grove, and he knew the families who gathered salmon farther downstream. “Who says it's wrong?”

“Men who are paid to know.”

Eli almost smiled. “That's not an answer.”

Calvin met his gaze without the least discomfort. “Mr. Catcher, the company is prepared to pay for this survey and for a favorable finding. It will also compensate affected residents under the applicable agreements. Your task is to supply figures. The law will decide the rest.”

There it was: a pleasant sentence laid over an ugly demand. Eli understood enough to feel unease. He also understood that the sum beside Calvin's draft could buy a new horse, put Mary through several years of school, and keep him out of the county jail for unpaid debts. He had mistaken that knowledge for a difficult moral question when it was, in truth, a simple one.

He signed.

The revised survey did not immediately destroy the village. For months nothing happened except meetings, letters and arguments over measurements. Eli told himself the fuss would settle. When Mara's father came to the survey office with an

older agreement, Eli was away on another line. When a family refused the proposed relocation payment, Calvin called them stubborn rather than wronged. The words made the dispute sound manageable, and Eli let himself be managed by them.

The first fire changed that. Eli returned to find smoke in the valley and wagons moving out along the muddy road. He learned later that armed contractors had arrived before the flames. When he questioned the survey clerk, the man told him to keep his opinions to himself. Calvin summoned him and asked for another set of measurements, this time placing the old creek bed outside the protected boundary.

“I won't put my name on a lie,” Eli said.

Calvin brought out the first survey. “Your name's already there.”

Eli looked at it. His pride had become a handle by which another man could drag him wherever he wished. He signed the second document, telling himself it would secure a smaller area and spare the homes beyond it. It did not. Within weeks the company had the wider line it wanted, and people were dead.

He left the survey office that summer. He said he was bored with paperwork. He drank the remaining money. He drifted from town to town, quarrelling with men who seemed prosperous and shooting one over a dispute he later told as a joke. He told himself he was free. At night, when he heard trains, he sometimes dreamed of the pen beside Calvin's desk.

Then he met Dean. The younger man had a habit of saying aloud what Eli wanted to bury. At first that made them quarrel. Later it made Eli feel, briefly, like the man he'd once hoped to be.

The wagon rattled over a bridge, bringing him back to the present. Mary was talking about blankets. Dean sat beside Eli with his boots propped against the seat, explaining at considerable length why the left wheel should not be trusted. Richard, surrounded by empty medicine boxes, had fallen asleep.

Eli looked at the little group and felt a tenderness so fierce it nearly frightened him. These were the people he might still

harm with his silence. He had not told them what the second survey meant. He did not know how to begin.

“What are you looking at?” Dean asked.

“Nothing.”

“You're doing it again.”

“Doing what?”

“Thinking so hard your face goes sour.”

Eli smiled. “Somebody's got to think for both of us.”

Dean shook his head. “That's a dangerous arrangement.”

At the edge of Hamilton they passed the old county marker that showed the distance to Red Willow. The stone was chipped, its letters half hidden by weeds. Eli thought about how simple it was to move a line on paper and how impossible it was to move the lives that had grown around it.

Mary climbed down first, went to help Richard, and then stopped beside her uncle. “Mara said we should come back,” she told him. “When they've made a list of what else they need.”

“We will.”

“Promise?”

He looked at her. His first instinct was to answer easily, as he always had. Instead he nodded and said, “I'll try to make it happen.”

Mary regarded him for a moment. It wasn't the confident promise she was used to, but she seemed to trust it more.

That evening Eli walked alone to the station road, where the old freight line curved east. The tracks made two parallel ribbons of black beneath the moon. He had helped choose the route; he knew every curve. Somewhere in the night an engine sounded its whistle, and he could almost hear Calvin saying the word progress as though it settled every account.

Eli took the old map from his coat, looked at his signature, and began to plan how he would get into the railway's records room. He had spent years pretending the past was a place he had left behind. Now he would have to go back into it with his eyes open.

CHAPTER 9

Old Debts

Calvin H. Douberville's office stood above the Jackson Ward Railway yard, with tall windows that turned the valley into a private exhibition. From his desk he could see the sawmill, the engine shed, the new trestle under construction, and the long ranks of logs hauled from the forest. He kept the windows clean. It was important, he liked to say, for a man to see what he owned.

His desk had come east around Cape Horn in the hold of a ship. The carpet came from a factory in England. The whiskey, when he served it to guests, bore a label that claimed an age Calvin had never had the patience to verify. Nothing inside the room smelled of the work below. He considered that a triumph of modern living.

Doug Barlow and Slim Kern stood before him. Doug had a fresh bruise along his jaw. Slim's right hand was wrapped in dirty cloth. Neither looked inclined to explain the other's injuries.

“Four men,” Calvin said, studying a short report. “Four employees of a company in which I retain a substantial interest.”

Doug shifted his weight. “Yes, sir.”

“Dead in the woods because two men fell into their camp?”

“Well, sir, they came down a hillside fighting, and then—”

Calvin raised one finger. Doug stopped. Calvin had cultivated the little gesture for years. He found it more effective than shouting.

“The young one?”

“Dean Peters. Drifter. Quick with a revolver. Slim says he gave him a lesson in Hamilton.”

Slim attempted a smile. “Cracked him good, sir.”

“Then why,” Calvin asked pleasantly, “is Mr. Peters still walking around?”

Neither man answered. Calvin turned a page.

“And the older one?”

“Eli Catcher.”

Something happened to Calvin's face. His smile remained, but it ceased to mean anything.

“Eli Catcher,” he repeated.

Doug mistook the pause for ignorance. “Used to survey for us a few years back.”

“I know what Mr. Catcher used to do.” Calvin walked to the window and watched a loaded timber wagon struggle through the mud. “And I had hoped he had developed the wisdom to remain where he was sent.”

He opened the safe behind a framed railway certificate. Inside were bundles of notes, a thick book with a red leather cover and a drawer of sealed contracts. He took out a bank draft and wrote a sum upon it with a practiced hand.

Five thousand dollars.

Doug made a small noise he couldn't quite stop.

Calvin folded the draft into an envelope. On a sheet of his letterhead he wrote, Come home, Mr. Catcher. Nothing else. He sealed the envelope and held it out.

“Offer him this. Tell him there is a place for a sensible man who knows his obligations.”

“And if he refuses?” Slim asked.

Calvin drew his gaze from the window. “Then find out what he knows. And only then, gentlemen, do whatever you must to keep it from traveling.”

He returned to his desk as though ordering a late luncheon.

In Hamilton, Eli was wrestling with a less elegant problem: handwriting. The journal lay on the rear table of the general store. He wrote a place name, squinted at it, crossed out half the letters and tried again. On the page above he had entered three dates, each attached to a particular survey section. On the next he drew a rough square to represent the warehouse where private guards kept their payroll records.

He was not a learned man, though he knew numbers well. He had spent years telling everyone that books were useless except for propping up short tables. Now he had two books, neither of which he dared show another soul.

Mary caught him staring at a blank line as if it had insulted him.

“Uncle?”

He closed the journal. “Hey, sweetheart.”

“What are you writing?”

“Love letters.”

“To whom?”

“Your Aunt Margaret.”

Mary leaned against the table. “She's been dead eleven years.”

“Explains why she never writes back.”

Mary smiled despite herself, then noticed the tremor in his fingers. He had not been sleeping. She knew the signs: too much coffee, little appetite, a cheerfulness that arrived too loudly and went away too soon.

“Something happened out there,” she said.

He began to argue. She put a hand over his.

“Not an accident on the trail. Something worse.”

Eli looked at the place where their hands met. He had known Mary since she was a child with skinned knees and fierce opinions. He had stood beside her when Margaret died and had found, to his shame, that he could comfort her only by promising things. It seemed he was still doing it.

“There are things a man ought to have done differently,” he said.

Mary waited.

“And things he ought not to have done at all.”

The shop bell rang. Doug Barlow came in with Slim behind him, filling the doorway with damp wool and trouble. Mary's hand left Eli's.

“We're closed to trouble,” she said.

Doug gave her a broad smile. “Miss Catcher. Lovely as ever.”

“Then you may admire me from the street.”

Doug ignored her. His eyes found Eli. “Mr. Douberville sends his regards.”

The old cowboy rose slowly. “Tell him I don't want them.”

Doug placed the envelope on the table. “He thought you might change your mind.”

From the storeroom came the soft thump of a sack set down. Dean appeared with grain dust on his sleeves. He recognized the visitors at once.

“Well, well,” he said. “Porky and Slim.”

Slim's hand moved toward his coat. Dean's revolver was out before the man had reached the second button.

“Don't,” Dean said.

Doug went still. Mary, who had seen the same pair leave Dean unconscious in the street, looked from one man to the other with deliberate calm.

“Put it away,” Eli told Dean.

“Old man, that fellow broke a bottle on my head.”

“I remember. I paid for the bandages.”

“He's reaching for a gun.”

“He's reaching for stupidity. Let him do it somewhere else.”

Dean kept the barrel trained until Slim slowly raised his hands. Eli took the envelope from the table.

“Tell Calvin I got it,” he said.

Doug's smile returned. “You'd do well to give it some thought.”

When they left, Dean rounded on Eli. “What in God's name was that?”

“An invitation.”

“From the man we think ordered half the trouble in this territory?”

Eli tucked the envelope into his coat.

“You know him,” Dean said. It wasn't a question anymore.

Mary stood between them, watching her uncle. Eli said nothing. Dean felt the old irritation rising: the maps, the silence at the worksite, the stake he'd seen Eli cover in Red Willow.

“What aren't you telling me?”

Eli's face hardened. “Enough.”

“Eli—”

“I said enough.”

The words were sharp enough to make Mary flinch. Dean stared at him. Then he collected the sack from the floor and went to the storeroom without another word.

Eli unfolded the bank draft after Mary had turned away. Five thousand dollars was a fortune. More than enough to take Mary far from Hamilton and give Dean a new start. More than enough to settle old debts, if debts could be counted only in dollars.

That evening he found Dean behind the saloon cleaning the cylinder of his revolver. The young man didn't look up when Eli sat beside him. Eli set down two small bottles.

“Peace offering.”

“Is it whiskey?”

“Of a sort.”

“Then you've begun to make amends.”

Eli uncorked his bottle and drank. For a while they listened to a horse stamping inside the livery stable. The town was settling around them, doors closing one by one.

“I used to work for Jackson Ward,” Eli said at last.

Dean's hands stopped moving.

“Surveys,” Eli continued. “Not the fancy engineering. Boundaries. Roads. Places where it was easy to put a track and places where someone else was already living.”

Dean looked at him. “Red Willow?”

Eli nodded. “They paid me to make a new map. Told me the old lines were wrong. Said everyone would be compensated when the company bought the claims.”

“And you believed them?”

“I wanted to.”

“That ain't the same thing.”

“No,” Eli said. “It ain't.”

He stared at the bottle in his hand. A man could remember a conversation differently after enough years. He could forget the exact price of an evening's drinking or the color of the coat a stranger had worn. But Eli remembered the survey office clearly: Calvin's smile, the papers spread over the desk, the pen placed neatly beside the draft. He remembered knowing the numbers did not add up. He remembered signing anyway.

“After the first families started moving,” he said, “I saw what they were doing. Told myself it was too late to make a fuss. Then the first people died. I told myself I didn't know it would happen.”

Dean took a careful breath. “Did you?”

Eli looked toward him, hurt by the question because it was just.

“Not all of it,” he said. “But enough that I should've asked questions. Enough that I ought to have walked out.”

Dean watched a moth wheel around the saloon lantern. “You drew the lines that put them out.”

“Yeah.”

“You let me ride with you all over this country, and you never said a word.”

“I was ashamed.”

“That's a poor excuse.”

“The only one I got.”

There was a long silence. Dean had spent years keeping company with men who justified their crimes with stories

about necessity. Eli, for once, was not justifying his. That made the anger harder to use.

“What are you going to do about it?” Dean asked.

Eli turned the empty bottle between his fingers. “Find the proof. Put it where Douberville can't buy it or burn it. Get those families home.”

“You got any proof?”

“Some.”

“Enough?”

“Not yet.”

Dean finished putting his pistol together. He stood, holstered it, and took the second bottle.

“You're buying breakfast,” he said.

Eli blinked. “What?”

“Every breakfast. Until I decide we're square.”

“Son, at the price of coffee you'll bankrupt me.”

“Then best get started.”

Dean walked toward the saloon. Eli remained seated until the light inside had grown soft and the moon rose over the station roof. Then he took Calvin's draft from his coat and tore it once, twice, and again. Five thousand dollars fell into the mud in pieces too small to redeem.

He had told Dean the truth as far as it went. But he had not told him about the second survey, the one he had approved after the first fire. Or about the contractor whose payroll he had helped conceal. Or about the meaning of the words witness settlement on a Jackson Ward account sheet.

He would tell Dean, he promised himself. Soon.

A man who was always promising soon did not always recognize how little time he had left.

CHAPTER 10

The Badge and the Bill

Sheriff Derrick McClean was not a romantic man. He had chosen law work because it meant regular pay, which was more than his father had earned tending a failing orchard, and because somebody in Hamilton needed to settle disputes without shooting the disputants. He had long ago discovered that the badge brought fewer advantages than the newspapers suggested. It made him responsible for men who drank, women who stole food because their families were hungry, and a town council that believed every problem could be solved by asking him to do more with less.

It had also brought Jackson Ward Railway into his life. The company paid taxes, employed laborers and contributed to a new streetlamp outside the station. It donated to the county poor fund, though usually with a photographer present. The same men who praised those gifts were the men who came to Derrick's office demanding that a family be removed for trespassing on a disputed claim.

One afternoon, shortly after Eli confessed his past to Dean, Derrick received a letter from the county judge. It requested his cooperation with railway security and encouraged him to treat interference with construction as an offense against lawful commerce. The judge used three paragraphs to say what the company clerk had said in five words: Stay out of our way.

Derrick put the letter under a paperweight, then fetched coffee he didn't want. Richard Spalding arrived a few minutes later to ask whether the deputy had found any word of the men who attacked Dean. Derrick showed him the judge's letter. Richard read it and sat down without being invited.

“You going to obey that?” the doctor asked.

“It's not an order.”

“That's why the paper is polite.”

Derrick rubbed his face. “The company employs half the men in town. We shut the yard, people go hungry. We let the company do as it likes, they become hungry anyway.”

“Then the company needs stopping, not Hamilton.”

“Easy enough to say from the surgery.”

Richard looked down at his hands. “I treated three of those workers last week. One had his fingers caught in a winch, and the foreman told me not to report the injury. If it made the district look dangerous, the contractor would lose a bonus.”

Derrick's jaw tightened. Richard continued.

“I've treated children from Red Willow. I've seen what happens when men turn suffering into a figure they can hide in a book. And you know what the worst part is? They have become so good at it that sometimes even I almost believe them.”

Outside, a wagon rattled across the square. Derrick thought of his oath, signed when he still imagined the law was something a man could simply carry around in his pocket. He had watched cases fail because witnesses disappeared or evidence became confused. He had allowed railway guards to patrol areas the town had not granted them, thinking they would move on after construction finished.

“I want records,” he said at last. “Not just accusations. Give me proof I can put before a judge who isn't on their payroll.”

Richard nodded. “Then perhaps we should stop scolding those two fools for looking.”

“I haven't stopped scolding 'em. I merely plan to do it while helping.”

At dusk Derrick went to the general store. Mary was closing the shutters. He asked if Eli had been visiting recently and whether he knew more about the company than he'd admitted. She looked away, which told him something.

“Mary,” he said gently, “I can't keep your uncle safe from a thing I don't understand.”

“He doesn't need anyone keeping him safe.”

“Everyone does, sometimes.”

She rested a hand on the shutter. “He thinks he can fix something he broke. I don't know what it is. Every time I ask, he makes a joke.”

Derrick considered that. “Then perhaps it's worse than he can say aloud.”

Across town Dean was making a discovery of his own. He had returned to the logging camp alone, circling far enough east that the railway patrols wouldn't see him. The bodies were gone, hauled away by company men. The cooking pot lay where it had fallen. So did the damaged kettle and one boot whose owner had not returned for it.

Dean had come for the man's wedding band. He hadn't taken it during the fight and had spent a week unable to forget the plain circle of metal on a dead hand. He found no band, but near the tent he discovered a small scrap of paper stuck beneath a broken board. It was a letter, wet and torn. The writing was uneven, like Eli's. It began with a woman's name and asked how the children were managing the cold. The rest was ruined.

He stood looking at it until the light changed.

Dean could justify what had happened: the men had drawn on him, the rifleman had ignored the warning, Eli had been forced to shoot the man at the fire. All of it could be true. Yet the men had left families, and that fact would not go away because he preferred to call them enemies. A company could hire poor men to do bad work, then turn their deaths into another grievance it used to hurt more people. Dean had become part of that chain without asking who had forged it.

He took the scrap back to Hamilton and handed it to Derrick. The sheriff studied it under the lamp.

“Found this at the camp,” Dean said. “Think you can find who wrote it?”

“Maybe. Why?”

“Somebody ought to know what happened. Not just the company.”

Derrick looked at him carefully. “That's a serious answer from a man who usually tries to avoid them.”

“Don't get used to it.”

The sheriff nodded and put the letter into his desk drawer beside the judge's instructions. He didn't know whether the two pieces of paper belonged in the same case, but they seemed to him the product of the same problem: men with money could describe the world for everyone else, while people without it were left arguing over the truth.

Before Dean went, Derrick said, “I don't imagine Eli's told you everything.”

Dean stopped at the door. “No.”

“You going to stay with him?”

“I reckon I am.”

“Even if it's worse than you think?”

Dean considered the question. “He's stayed with me through plenty that's worse than I care to think about.”

Derrick leaned back. “Then make sure you two don't get yourselves buried trying to be loyal.”

Dean touched the brim of his hat. “We'll do our best.”

He went back into the street, where the lamplight from the station glowed over the mud. For a little while he stood listening to the far-off engine, trying to decide whether loyalty meant protecting Eli from consequences or helping him face them. He knew which answer the old man would prefer. He wasn't sure it was the right one.

CHAPTER 11

The Founders' Supper

The Jackson Ward Railway threw a party for Hamilton that looked, from the outside, like a gift. The town hall was hung with ribbons. A brass band played on the boardwalk. Bright posters announced a new age of prosperity. Barrels of beer arrived for the workers, cases of wine for the investors, and a single wagon of imported champagne for those who would never be asked to lay a rail.

Mary had been invited because her store supplied half the refreshments and because her aunt had once done business with the railway's first purchasing agent. She regarded the invitation as a duty. Eli regarded it as a chance to steal something. Dean regarded it as a good way to be seen wearing his only decent shirt.

When Mary emerged from the store in a blue dress, he forgot even that.

She stopped at the bottom step. “Well?”

Dean looked at her. “You look ... clean.”

Mary's smile became a question. “Clean?”

“Not— I meant. You look—”

Eli doubled over, laughing so hard that he had to grab the rail. “Clean! Oh, boy, that's poetry!”

Mary walked down the step and took Dean's arm. “Come inside before you improve the compliment.”

Dean obeyed gladly. Eli called after them, offering to write Dean a list of better things to say. Dean did not turn around, although Mary heard him mutter something about buying the old man a muzzle.

Inside, Hamilton's respectable people were making a vigorous effort to forget what Hamilton usually smelled like. Chandeliers gave the room a soft glow. The butcher wore a clean coat. A railroad foreman stood uneasily near a piano,

twisting a hat in his big hands. Calvin Douberville moved among them as if he were attending an event staged in his own honor—which, in fairness, he was.

He was a handsome man in a careful way, silver beginning at his temples, dark suit fitted without a wrinkle. He shook hands warmly. He remembered names. He mentioned the new schoolhouse, the hospital the company intended to finance, the commerce the railway would bring. When he spoke about opportunity, people listened; when he spoke about land, he spoke in quantities.

Dean watched him charm an elderly widow who had opposed the new line only the month before. He wondered whether a man could grow rich enough to make his voice sound like a promise.

Derrick stood near the punch bowl, looking discontented in a collar that was choking him. He had been ordered by the town council to provide security for the event. Doctor Spalding had been pressed into attending as proof of the railway's benevolence toward public health. Neither enjoyed the privilege.

“See the big fellow at the door?” Derrick murmured as Dean joined him. “That's one of Calvin's personal guards. Came in yesterday from the eastern offices.”

“I saw him.”

“And the two on the balcony?”

“Also guards.”

“Smart boy.”

Dean took a drink of punch and made a face. “Good Lord. What's in this?”

“An expensive reason to stay sober.”

The dance began. Mary claimed Dean before he could escape, and he discovered that stepping aside from bullets had taught him surprisingly little about stepping around another person's skirts. He trod on her shoe twice. She guided his hand and pretended not to notice.

“Do you do anything gracefully?” she asked.

“Draw a gun.”

“Uncle Eli says you're decent at falling off horses.”

“He started that story. He was standing on the wrong side of the horse.”

She laughed and looked past his shoulder. Eli was at the far end of the room, apparently making himself useful beside a tray of pastries. For a moment Dean saw the older man glance toward the window, where the railway offices stood across the square. Then Eli set his plate down and disappeared through a side door.

“Mary,” Dean said, suddenly alert, “your uncle isn't where he said he'd be.”

She followed his gaze. “Then he's either making trouble or already in it.”

“That narrows it down.”

Eli crossed the alley behind the hall and waited for a carriage to pass before approaching the railway administration building. He had spent enough years in its offices to know how the locks worked, which windows stuck, and where the clerks kept their keys. He knew, too, that Calvin's generosity extended to his employees only while they were useful. The back entrance was guarded by a man who had been given more whiskey than sense.

Eli stepped quietly behind him, pressed a pistol against his back and ordered him to put his hands up. The man turned, reached too quickly for his own revolver, and took a blow to the head. Eli eased him into a chair. He had no particular desire to make another widow tonight.

Inside, the office smelled of polished wood and paper. Eli moved down the familiar corridor and found the locked records room. He opened it with a borrowed key. Shelves rose floor to ceiling. The company had documented its business with the enthusiasm of a church recording sins it hoped never to confess.

Eli found a shipment register, a payroll book, and a thick ledger bound in red leather. He laid them side by side on the desk beneath a lamp. At first the entries looked harmless, all abbreviated names and numbers. Then he found the dates.

Blackwater Creek, three days before the families disappeared. A payment to special contractors. Red Willow, the

week before the fires. Kerosene, hired rifles, transport wagons. Carson's Gorge, the day after the surveyors' accident. A payment described as witness settlement.

He read that line three times.

His name appeared elsewhere, beside the altered reservation boundary. He stared at his signature until it seemed the letters might crawl from the page and accuse him. Then he began copying. He took the pages that mattered most, working quickly, marking dates and sealing the copies in his satchel. At last he found a letter authorizing forced removal from the district, signed by Calvin and countersigned by a territorial land agent. He slipped it inside his coat.

“Still a diligent worker, Mr. Catcher.”

Calvin stood in the doorway. Two guards waited behind him.

Eli looked up. A man sometimes prepares an answer to a question so often that when the question comes, the answer is useless. He had imagined this meeting a hundred times. Now all he could think of was how young the guard by the door looked.

“You murdering son of a bitch,” he said.

Calvin entered slowly. “Such language in a records office.”

“You paid them to burn the houses.”

“I paid men to clear disputed property. What they chose to do, within the terms of their contracts, was a matter for their judgment.”

“Children died.”

Calvin's expression became patient, as though explaining figures to a tiresome investor. “You survey a boundary and imagine it harmless. I build the line and you call it violence. But we're both drawing lines on a map, Eli. The difference is that mine actually lead somewhere.”

“You told them people they'd be paid.”

“They were offered compensation.”

“You offered it after you'd moved the boundary out from under their feet.”

Calvin rested a hand on the ledger. “And you signed the survey.”

Eli flinched. Calvin saw it and smiled.

“The courts will be interested in that signature. Should I mention the second survey? The one you approved when the smoke from Red Willow hadn't yet settled?”

“I was trying to keep the company from taking more.”

“You were trying to keep your pay.”

Eli knew there was enough truth in that to make denial worthless. He looked toward the doorway, then toward the high window behind the desk.

“I won't help you hide it anymore.”

Calvin glanced at the satchel. “I think you misunderstand your position.”

Eli lifted the ledger and hurled it into Calvin's face. The businessman staggered back into a guard. Eli fired once, hitting the second man before he could bring his rifle around. The office became a confusion of glass, smoke and shouted orders. Eli flung a chair into the lamp, smashed the window with his shoulder, and went out into the night in a rain of broken panes.

He hit the mud hard, got up badly, and ran.

By the time Dean saw him coming around the administration building, Eli had a cut across his cheek and half the office shouting after him.

“Eli!”

“Run!”

Shots followed. Dean drew and fired toward the corner, forcing the guards back. Mary saw both men and made a decision without consulting either. She seized the reins of a produce wagon standing near the town hall, climbed onto the seat, and called, “Get in!”

“Mary, what the hell—” Dean began.

“Now!”

Eli threw himself into the back, nearly going through a crate of cabbages. Dean climbed beside Mary as she lashed the horses forward. They tore down the main street with Doug shouting somewhere behind them. A guard stepped into the road and discovered that Mary Catcher drove a team with substantially less concern for his personal safety than he had expected. He leapt clear as the wagon passed.

“What did you do?” Dean shouted over the wheels.

“Found something!” Eli yelled.

“What?”

“Bad news!”

Dean looked at the gunfire fading behind them. “You think?”

Mary steered them out of Hamilton and up the old logging road. She didn't slow until the last lamplight disappeared behind the trees.

Hours later they reached a hunting cabin that belonged, by an improbable series of favors, to a man who had not visited it in years. The place was dusty but sound, with a stone fireplace and floorboards that complained in three different voices. Dean tended the horses while Mary set a kettle over the fire. Eli spread the documents beneath the lamp, his hands shaking with cold and exertion.

They read until the light was nearly gone. Mary arranged the copied accounts in date order and found the pattern quickly: purchases before fires, hired guards before relocations, payments to officials before court rulings. Dean read the line witness settlement and felt a hollow place open in his stomach. He thought of the men he had killed in the logging camp and wondered what orders those men had followed, and who had written them.

“Take it to Derrick,” he said.

“Derrick can arrest a man,” Eli replied, “but Calvin can hire ten men to say this is forged. We need the original ledger, the seal, and folks willing to stand in court and swear what happened.”

Mary looked up from the papers. “What about the families in that compound?”

“We get them out,” Eli said. “They're witnesses too. We don't leave them behind.”

“Where's the original?” Dean asked.

“Office car. Douberville keeps his important books close when he travels. There's a shipment due east soon.”

Dean stared at the maps on the table. They were planning crimes now with the solemnity of respectable men planning dinner. He rubbed his bruised head and sighed.

“Well. I guess we're robbing a train.”

Eli grinned for the first time that night. Mary did not. She had noticed, as she arranged the papers, how many entries carried Eli's signature. She had not yet asked him about the oldest dates, and he had not yet volunteered the answer.

Outside the cabin, a horse stood still beneath the trees. A man watched a slit of light at the shutters, then turned his horse down the road toward Hamilton.

CHAPTER 12

The Last Good Supper

The cabin had no proper kitchen, but Mary made a supper out of what they had brought and what Eli discovered in the pantry: potatoes, dried beans, two onions and a strip of salt pork of uncertain age. Dean suggested leaving the pork untouched until it had signed a written statement concerning its intentions. Eli said a man who'd spent the last hour dodging bullets had no right to be particular about supper.

The fire warmed the room slowly. Outside, the rain had stopped and the trees held the water in their branches. Mary chopped the onions with a knife that had no proper handle. Eli sat at the table with the stolen papers spread before him, trying to decide which needed copying again before he moved them. Dean cleaned mud from the floor, mostly because Mary had handed him a broom and told him to make himself useful.

“You put that dust back where it came from,” she said when he pushed everything toward the hearth.

“It's a very promising pile.”

“It's a mess.”

“Then it's got a lot in common with us.”

Eli looked up from the table. “Don't drag me into your housekeeping failures.”

“You were the one who came through a window tonight.”

“A planned exit.”

“You landed in the cabbages.”

“That, too, was planned.”

Mary laughed. Dean watched her from behind the broom and felt a sudden tenderness that frightened him more than the shots they'd survived. She was standing in a poor cabin making supper for two wanted men, and for a little while the room had the shape of a home.

When the beans were ready, they ate from mismatched bowls with their boots off and their guns close. Eli told a story about a winter spent prospecting above the snow line, where a mule had eaten the map and left him to navigate by a creek that had frozen. Dean interrupted to point out that a man who lost a route because a mule ate his map ought not to be trusted with any other maps. Eli countered that the mule had been a better cartographer than Dean.

Mary listened, smiling, then asked whether there had really been a woman behind the shooting that had driven Eli out of his last town.

The room went very quiet.

Dean grinned. “Yes. An ugly one.”

Eli closed his eyes. “Don't start.”

“What was her name?” Mary asked.

Eli sighed. “Her name was Alice. She was not ugly.”

Dean made a face that suggested he possessed documentary evidence to the contrary. Eli pointed his spoon at him.

“Alice was kind, and she worked harder than any man I ever met. The fellow I shot had been beating her. I tried to stop him. He pulled a gun. I shot him.”

Mary looked at him with surprise. “You never told me that.”

“Didn't think you'd approve of how it finished.”

“Did he die?”

“Yes.” Eli put the spoon down. “And before either of you tells me I ought to have taken him to the sheriff, I know. Maybe I could've done it differently. I was younger and angry, and I took the quick answer.”

Dean stared into his bowl. He had never heard Eli explain the fight without a punch line. He thought about the logging camp and the man with the wedding band. Quick answers were often the ones a man spent the longest time paying for.

Mary reached across the table and took her uncle's hand. “I don't approve of men beating women either.”

Eli smiled. “Well, that's one thing we've managed to agree on.”

They finished eating in a more thoughtful silence. Then Dean volunteered to wash the dishes, which startled them all.

Mary pretended to faint. Eli announced that the world must be ending. Dean retaliated by splashing cold water toward both of them and was ordered to take the pan outside.

Later, when the fire had burned down to embers, Mary walked onto the porch. The air was sweet with wet leaves. She could see a narrow strip of sky between the black trees, a place where the stars showed despite the clouds. Dean came out carrying two cups of water. He handed her one and leaned against the rail.

“Long day,” he said.

“Long week.”

He nodded. They stood together for a while listening to a stream below the cabin.

“Do you ever think about stopping?” she asked.

“Stopping what?”

“Running. Wandering. Finding trouble everywhere you go.”

Dean smiled faintly. “It's usually trouble that finds me.”

“Do you ever want a home?”

The question unsettled him. He had spent so much of his life imagining the next town that he'd ceased imagining a place to remain. A house, to Dean, had always meant somebody else could come to the door and tell him to leave.

“I did once,” he said. “Long time ago.”

“What happened?”

“Made mistakes. Lost things I couldn't get back.”

Mary studied him, waiting for more. He looked down at his hands. He had not spoken much about the woman in the photograph he sometimes carried. She had been his mother, dead after a fever in a mining camp; he'd spent the next years sleeping wherever a man would let him work. He had been too young to call it grief and too proud to admit what he'd lost.

“I don't know if I know how,” he said at last. “To be somebody who stays.”

Mary leaned against his shoulder. “You can learn.”

He looked at her. “You sound very sure.”

“I'm not. But I'm willing to find out.”

They stood there until the cold drove them inside. Dean gave her the cot without arguing this time. Eli had already settled on

the chair, boots beside the hearth, his hat on the table. He watched Mary close the bedroom door, then looked at Dean with a crooked smile.

“You clean up pretty well, boy.”

“Don't.”

“I'm only saying.”

“Don't say.”

Eli chuckled softly. Dean lowered himself to the floor with a rolled blanket under his head. The lamp's light made long shadows across the ceiling.

“Eli,” he said after a while.

“Hmm?”

“What happens if we get that ledger and the judge still won't listen?”

Eli took a long time to answer. “We find another judge.”

“And if Calvin buys him too?”

“Then we find more people who'll stand together than he can afford to buy.”

Dean considered that. It sounded less like Eli than he expected, and more like something Mara might say. He was beginning to understand the old man had learned from people he once refused to hear.

“Whatever happens,” Dean said, “you tell Mary the rest of your story.”

Eli's eyes moved to the closed door. “I will.”

“Promise me.”

A pause. “I'll do my best.”

Dean turned onto his side. The answer did not satisfy him, but he was too tired to argue. Before sleep claimed him, he heard Eli moving quietly about the table, unfolding papers and writing. He imagined another list of dates. He did not know that the old man was beginning a letter.

Outside, a horse snorted softly in its sleep. The cabin settled around them. For a few hours they were warm and fed, and nobody was shooting at them. In the morning Eli would be gone, and Dean would spend years wishing he'd stayed awake a little longer to hear his friend tell one more terrible joke.

CHAPTER 13

The Last Trail

Before dawn Eli sat at the cabin table with his journal open and a pen pinched awkwardly between thick fingers. Dean slept on the floor in front of the cold hearth. Mary had been given the cot; she'd refused it twice before Dean threatened to sleep outside unless she took it. The quiet was so complete that Eli could hear the pen nib scratch each uncertain word.

He had not intended to write a confession. At first he'd bought the journal to keep dates and numbers, a poor man's substitute for the official records he knew Calvin could make disappear. But each time he wrote a place name—Red Willow, Blackwater Creek, Carson's Gorge—the memory of his own hand on the altered surveys came back. The journal had grown into an argument with himself, and he was losing.

He wrote more slowly now. He named the first payment, the second survey, the contractor who had approached him after the Red Willow fire. He wrote that he had suspected the families were in danger, that he had accepted the money anyway, that shame had become an excuse for silence. He did not know whether a court would believe it. He knew only that Dean deserved to hear it from him.

At last he took a fresh sheet and began a letter.

Dean, he wrote.

If you're reading this, things likely went worse than I hoped. I ain't been the sort of man worth writing songs about, unless the songs are meant to keep children from following my example...

He stopped often. He crossed out the word good when he tried to describe himself. He wrote about Mary and about the way Dean had become, without either of them saying it, the nearest thing to a son he had ever had. He asked the younger man not to let anger devour the people he still loved. He asked

him to see the evidence into the hands of someone who could use it.

He wanted to write forgive me. Instead, after a long time, he wrote I'm sorry.

He wrapped the journal and letter in oilcloth and lifted a loose board beneath the iron stove. There was space enough there to hide the bundle. He marked the underside of the stove with a small white chalk cross and placed the board back carefully. In his satchel he left a folded sketch of the cabin floor, tucked beneath an old pocket compass. It was the sort of clue Dean would recognize, provided he lived to look for it.

At first light, when Mary stirred, Eli was outside saddling the horses. She came onto the porch carrying his coat.

“You left this by the fire.”

“Trying to develop a habit of not carrying everything I own.”

She looked toward the trees. “You and Dean aren't going alone, are you?”

“Just up to the old survey station.”

“That isn't an answer.”

“You've been spending too much time with him.”

Mary folded the coat over her arm. “Uncle, I know you've done things you're ashamed of. I'm not a child. But you don't have to fix every one of them by yourself.”

He took the coat and rested his hands briefly on her shoulders. The resemblance to Margaret was strongest when Mary was worried. Eli looked at her face and nearly told her everything. Instead he kissed her forehead.

“You look after that fool for me,” he said.

She frowned. “He can look after himself.”

“That's what worries me.”

Dean emerged behind them, fastening his gun belt. “What's all this whispering?”

“Your funeral arrangements,” Eli said. “Mary wanted the inexpensive box.”

“Good. I'd hate to cost either of you money.”

They rode before the sun cleared the ridge. The morning was cold enough for their breath to show, but the woods were brightening. Dean talked about Mary's kiss on the cheek the

evening before, pretending it had been an accident while inviting Eli to argue otherwise. Eli obliged with enthusiasm.

“She likes you, boy.”

“You don't know that.”

“She keeps looking at you the way a hungry dog looks at a butcher's window.”

Dean nearly choked. “For God's sake.”

Eli laughed so hard that he had to steady his saddle. “I ain't letting that go until the day I die.”

The words slipped out lightly. When neither man laughed afterward, Eli cleared his throat and pointed at the trail ahead.

“Come on. Daylight's wasting.”

They rode through the clearing where, a week earlier, they had found the first great stump. The crow was gone. A length of railway chain now lay beside the raw wood. Eli avoided looking at it.

At a bend in the trail he stopped and dismounted. Fresh horseshoe prints cut across the road, and the ground around them was too deeply marked for a lone traveler.

“How many?” Dean asked.

“More than I'd like.”

A rifle shot broke the quiet and sent bark spinning from the tree above Dean's shoulder.

Both men went for cover. From the ridge came Doug Barlow's voice, ordering his men down toward the road. Dean fired at the first rider to appear. The man fell from his saddle. Eli dropped behind a fallen trunk and returned fire with the cool determination of somebody who had been frightened too many times to waste much movement on it.

“They knew we were coming!” Dean shouted.

“Thought they might!”

“You thought—?”

Eli fired again. “Bad time for a lecture!”

The gunmen spread through the trees. One went east to cut off the trail; two more moved along the slope. The partners held them as long as they could, but the distance between their hiding places widened as each sought better cover. Dean saw

Eli's horse rear when a bullet struck the ground at its feet. The old man went down, then rose with his shoulder bleeding.

“Eli!”

“I'm all right!”

It was the sort of lie that had kept Eli alive for years. This time it was less convincing.

Eli caught his satchel from the saddle and made for the ravine. Dean tried to follow, but rifle shots pinned him behind a mossy log. He shot one man who crossed the clearing too quickly, then heard another crash through the brush below him. The old survey track curved downhill toward the creek. If Eli reached it, he might still get away.

Dean scrambled to his feet and ran after him.

The fight became scattered sounds among the trunks. Eli's shoulder soaked his sleeve, and the satchel slapped against his hip. He had no strength to draw again. He forced himself onward because the papers, even the incomplete ones, were more than he had possessed a week before. If he could get them away from Calvin, it might be enough.

He climbed the low ridge and stumbled against a redwood. His white hat slipped; he pulled it down and kept moving. Behind him came the crack of another shot. A branch broke at his shoulder.

“ELI!”

Dean's voice, somewhere behind him. Eli turned with sudden, foolish relief.

On the rise beyond the clearing stood Calvin H. Douberville. He had come up the old company road with a handful of trusted men, unwilling to leave this particular problem to Doug. His coat was immaculate except for a wet hem. He held a revolver with both hands, careful and steady.

Dean saw him a heartbeat too late. He shouted, but his warning was swallowed by the gunshot.

Eli twisted as the bullet struck his chest. He fell backward into the ferns. His satchel landed a few feet away, and the white hat rose from his head in a slow, absurd arc before settling beside him.

Dean's world narrowed to the patch of earth where his friend had fallen. Two gunmen rushed from the trees toward Eli. Dean fired at both; one went down beside a log, the other fell against the bank. Calvin stepped out of sight beyond the rise. Dean fired once at the place where he had stood, then realized he had no rounds left.

He ran to Eli.

The old cowboy was lying on his back, staring through the branches. Dean knelt beside him and found blood beneath the coat. It was too much. His hands went to Eli's wrist, his neck, anywhere a pulse might be hiding.

“Come on, old man,” he said. “Come on. You ain't doing this.”

Eli's lips moved. Dean leaned closer, straining to hear. No words came. He pressed his hand to the wound as though force alone might hold a life inside a body.

“Not like this,” he whispered.

For one moment Eli's eyes found his. The look was weary and affectionate and full of things the older man hadn't managed to say. Then it was gone.

The forest returned around them. Water moved somewhere close. Dean could hear his own breathing and the distant clatter of a horse on the survey road. He did not know how long he knelt there.

A shout came from the ridge. More gunmen were approaching.

Dean picked up the satchel, then the white hat. He stood over the man who had been his last reliable companion in a

life that had offered few. His revolver hung at his side, the barrel bright with smoke.

"So long, Partner," he said.

He had meant to make a joke. Something Eli would have laughed at. Nothing came.

Dean backed away, then turned and ran through the trees. He carried the white hat in one hand and the satchel in the other. He did not look back. He was afraid that if he did, he would never be able to leave.

The words spoken in the forest were the words from the beginning, but the truth was different from the way it had looked. The stranger had been Dean all along. Calvin had fired the fatal shot. Dean had arrived only in time to say goodbye.

CHAPTER 14

The White Hat

The rain lasted three days. By the third, Hamilton's streets had become long brown trenches and the cemetery above town lay beneath a low cloud. Eli Catcher's coffin was made of plain boards from the carpenter's yard. The carpenter had refused payment when he learned whose name would go on it. He had owed the old man a favor, though he declined to explain the circumstances to the sheriff.

Dean stood beside Mary while Derrick spoke. Doctor Spalding held his hat in both hands, and Mara Wren stood a little apart with two people from Red Willow. There was no official company representative. Dean had not expected one; he was not certain he could have remained still if one had appeared.

“Eli Catcher,” Derrick began, “was not what most folks would call a respectable man.”

A few people smiled despite themselves. Mary kept her eyes on the coffin.

“He drank too much, talked too much, and appeared to regard the county jail as a place where his friends could visit him without paying for a room. He gave me more trouble than any six men I've arrested.”

Derrick paused. Rain dripped from the brim of his hat.

“But when it mattered, he tried to do the right thing. I reckon that ought to count for something.”

Dean heard the words and hated their smallness. Tried to do the right thing. Eli was a man who told bad jokes, cheated at cards and worried when Mary stayed out after dark. He had bought Dean boots once when the soles of his own were nearly worn through. He had made Dean angry on a hundred mornings and made him laugh on a hundred nights. There was no way to fit such a man into a speech.

The coffin went into the ground. Mary made a small broken sound. Dean put an arm around her, feeling how much effort she was spending merely to stand.

“I should've stayed with him,” he said.

She shook her head. “You couldn't have known.”

“I heard it. I heard the shot.” His voice thickened. “I was right there.”

She leaned against him. He looked down at the grave, remembering Eli's face in the last moment. He had seen men die before. It had never felt like this, as though the whole country had lost an argument it might once have won.

Afterward he went upstairs to Eli's room above the saloon. The old cowboy's possessions occupied less space than Dean expected: two shirts, a chipped washbasin, a spare boot with a broken heel, a pocketknife, a half-empty tobacco tin, and a set of cards so marked that even a blind man might have won with them. A loose floorboard held three silver coins and a photograph of Margaret. Mary had never seen the photograph before. Dean put it aside for her.

He opened the satchel from the forest. Inside were copied records, a pocket compass and a folded sketch of a floor. Eli

had drawn the hunting cabin's stone hearth, a crooked table, and the iron stove marked with a cross.

Dean stared at the drawing. He could almost hear the old man telling him, with that particular grin, that he had to put his nose down close to the floor to find the truth.

Derrick came up the stairs to find Dean sitting with the sketch in his hands.

“Mary says you haven't eaten.”

“Been occupied.”

“By what?”

Dean handed him the paper. “By an old man who never told me anything straight.”

That night, after the roads had become barely passable, Dean returned to the hunting cabin with Derrick and Mary. They lit the lamp and moved the stove enough to lift the board beneath it. There was the oilcloth bundle. Dean carried it to the table and opened it as carefully as if the paper could break.

The journal contained dates, names, payroll figures and maps in Eli's crooked hand. The earlier pages were brief. The later ones had grown crowded. Mary read the entries about Red Willow, then stopped at her uncle's confession. She put a hand over her mouth.

“Did you know?” she asked Dean.

“Some of it.”

“Not all.”

“No.”

She nodded slowly, tears gathering. “He should've told me.”

Dean could not argue. She was right. He had wanted Eli to tell him, too. The fact that the man had died trying to undo his wrongdoing did not make what he had done disappear. Mary sat by the window for a long while with the journal in her lap, reading each page and letting it hurt.

A separate envelope held a letter addressed to Dean. He recognized Eli's handwriting immediately. He read it once silently, then again more slowly. The letter spoke of a life that had gone wrong in quiet, ordinary ways before the spectacular wrongs began. It spoke of Mary. It spoke of the people at Red Willow. It asked Dean not to turn the old man's death into another excuse for violence.

And at the end it said, You're the nearest thing to a son I ever had. I hope I made that mean something good.

Dean lowered the paper. He had no memory of deciding to cry. His face was wet, and the words blurred when he tried to read them again.

Mary came over and sat beside him. Neither asked the other to stop grieving. They had both loved a man who had failed them in some ways and saved them in others. There was no clean name for that love, but it remained.

When Derrick finished reading the journal, he closed it with both hands.

“There's enough here to reopen every case,” he said.

“Then do it,” Dean replied.

“Handwritten notes won't put Douberville in chains. The company will deny the signatures, buy witnesses, lose records, make us look foolish. We need the originals and the people who saw what happened.”

Dean looked at Eli's letter on the table. He folded it and put it inside his coat.

“Then we'll get both,” he said.

Derrick took a long breath. “This doesn't have to become a war.”

“It's already one,” Mary said quietly. Both men turned to her.

She was still holding the journal. Her tears had dried, leaving her face pale and determined.

“The question is whether anybody besides the company gets to fight it.”

For the first time since the funeral, Dean looked at her and saw not only the woman he feared losing but someone who had made a decision of her own.

Outside, rain drummed on the cabin roof. The three of them bent over the table beneath the lamp and began to read.

CHAPTER 15

What a Man Leaves Behind

On the fourth morning after the funeral, Mary returned to Eli's room alone. She carried a box, a clean cloth and the sort of determined expression she'd worn as a child when sorting the tangled contents of a drawer. The room still smelled of tobacco and the lavender soap she had sent him for Christmas. He had complained about the scent until the day he died, then used every piece she bought him.

She opened the wardrobe. There was an old coat with a patch she'd sewn over a tear, two shirts too thin for winter and a scarf Margaret had knitted years before Mary was old enough to remember it being made. Eli had kept the scarf after Margaret's death, though he always claimed it was too warm for anything but a mountain blizzard. Mary folded it carefully.

In the boot beneath the bed she found a small bag of marbles, three coins from different states and an ivory button. The button belonged to her aunt's wedding dress. She sat on the floor holding it, suddenly undone by the way a man's whole life could hide in such ordinary things.

She knew what Eli had done. The journal had made her read the words with her own eyes. She had been angry enough to throw it across the cabin before remembering that broken paper could no longer accuse anyone. The people at Red Willow had lost homes because Eli chose money, then chose silence. Her grief did not cancel that. Neither did her love.

Dean knocked on the open door. He carried a plate of breakfast, two cups of coffee, and a bruised look that Richard had threatened to charge extra for if he acquired it again.

“Thought you might be hungry,” he said.

Mary wiped her face. “I'm not.”

“Then I'll eat both. But you'll have to watch, and I ain't a pretty eater.”

She almost smiled. Dean set the plate down beside the bed and sat on the floor across from her. He looked at the button in her hand.

“What is it?”

“Aunt Margaret's. From her dress.”

Dean nodded. He knew nothing about the button. He knew enough not to pretend.

“Did he ever tell you why he kept the journal?” she asked.

“Thought he needed to remember the numbers.”

“He could barely write.”

“He managed.”

She looked up. “How much did you know before he died?”

Dean took a long breath. “That he'd drawn the first survey. That he got paid. That there were things he didn't want to tell me. I knew he was ashamed. Didn't know the rest.”

“Would you have stayed if you had?”

It was a fair question and a cruel one to answer. Dean considered her face, then the little room around them. “Yes,” he said. “But I might've told him harder that he was wrong.”

Mary nodded slowly. “I keep wanting to ask him why. Then I remember he's gone, and I get angry at him for that too.”

Dean looked at the window. “I asked him a hundred times why he did foolish things. He had an answer for every one. Not a good answer, mind you. But an answer.”

“Always a joke.”

“Usually.”

Mary laughed briefly. “He used to come home and make the whole kitchen smell of wet horses. Aunt Margaret would make him wash at the pump before she let him eat. One winter he came back with a goose he'd stolen from a farmer who'd beaten his own dog. Said he'd liberated the bird on moral grounds.”

“What happened to it?”

“Aunt Margaret made us return it. Eli tried to argue. The goose bit him.”

Dean laughed properly. “I'd give a week's wages to have seen that.”

Mary put the button into the box. “He loved us. That was real. And he did a terrible thing. That's real too.”

Dean set his coffee down. “Maybe we honor him by telling both truths.”

The words were awkward, more earnest than he liked, but Mary seemed to take them seriously. She reached across the boards and squeezed his hand. Then she ate half the breakfast, though she said it was only to stop him from making a mess.

In the afternoon she rode with him to Red Willow. Mara met them near the repaired pump, her sleeves rolled up and her hair tied away from her face. Children carried water in small buckets while Jonah fitted a new iron collar onto the pipe. It was difficult work. Every repair reminded the people of what had been destroyed, but the sound of clean water returning to the trough brought a small cheer.

Mary gave Mara Eli's confession to read. She had copied it carefully so the original journal could remain hidden. Mara took the pages into the shade of a canvas shelter and read them from beginning to end. When she finished, she was quiet for some time.

“He knew,” she said at last.

Mary nodded. “More than he told us.”

“He also named men we couldn't name before.”

“We want to help bring them to court.”

Mara placed the papers on the table. “Then let us decide how our testimony is used. I've had enough outsiders speaking for us, even when they believe they're doing good.”

Mary flushed slightly. “You're right.”

Dean thought of the way Eli had drawn a line on a map and told himself the law would settle what happened afterward. He saw why Mara was careful with promises. Every promise to help had once carried a bill she had not agreed to pay.

“What do you need?” he asked her.

“Copies of every statement. An independent recorder. A chance for the families to read what they'll be asked to swear. And we need the prisoners back. Some of the people who saw the first attacks are still behind that fence.”

“We're working on it,” Dean said.

“Then work carefully.”

On the ride back Mary rode beside Dean instead of behind him. The sun was low, and the hills had begun to turn blue. They spoke little. It was a comfort to be able to remain silent without the silence feeling like a quarrel.

Near Hamilton, Mary pointed toward a field where horses grazed behind a split-rail fence. “Eli told me he wanted a place like that someday.”

“Did he?”

“A little ranch. Two horses, maybe a few cows. He never said where he'd find the money.”

Dean smiled sadly. “I reckon he planned to win it at cards.”

“He cheated at cards.”

“Only against men who were cheating worse.”

She looked at him. “Was that true?”

Dean considered. “Not always.”

Mary laughed. The sound carried into the evening, and for the first time since Eli died, Dean felt something other than guilt when he heard it. He felt that the old man would have recognized the moment and ruined it with a joke. The thought hurt. It also kept him riding.

CHAPTER 16

Behind the Fence

The holding compound at Carson's Passage had once been a logging dormitory, three long buildings around a yard where work horses stood and wagons were repaired. Jackson Ward had built a fence around it after the first removals. The company described the place as temporary accommodation for displaced families. Everyone who had been inside described it differently.

Mara wanted the names of the people kept there. Mary wanted to know whether the railway was moving them soon. Neither was satisfied with the reports that came through the station, and neither believed waiting for the territorial investigator would keep the prisoners alive.

They took the old quarry path at dusk, traveling on foot so no horse would sound against the stones. Jonah had shown them a place where the fence crossed a dry creek bed, hidden from the main guard tower by a stand of alder. Mara had walked the area before the company installed its posts. She knew the route even in the fading light.

“I don't like this,” Mary whispered.

“You don't have to.”

“That's not what I meant.”

Mara glanced back and almost smiled. “I know.”

They reached the creek bed and crouched beneath the branches. Through a narrow gap in the fence they could see the yard. Women carried buckets between the buildings. A man with a limp swept the steps under the watch of a guard. Children sat near the far wall, too quiet for a place where children ought to have been making noise.

Mary took out a small notebook. Mara had drawn a plan of the compound from memory. They counted the buildings, noted the guards' positions and watched the gate open for a

wagon carrying sacks of flour. A clerk checked the load, then closed the gate behind it. Every movement suggested the place was meant to appear orderly. That made the locked doors more disturbing, not less.

Near the eastern barracks a woman came out carrying a blanket. Mara recognized her. She raised one hand briefly, palm inward, a signal they had agreed upon when visits were still permitted. The woman paused, looked toward the fence, and answered with a slight movement of her own.

“That's Mrs. Talan,” Mara whispered. “She'll know who is still here.”

A guard crossed between them. They waited until he was gone. Then Mara moved along the creek bed to the place where rain had cut a small hollow beneath the boards. She pushed a folded note through the gap, weighted it with a stone. If Mrs. Talan saw it, she could pass back a list in the same place.

Mary looked toward the nearest building. “Do you think Calvin plans to put them on the train?”

“Yes,” Mara said. “He'll call it another relocation. It gives him a way to take them out of the district before they can speak.”

“What if he takes them somewhere worse?”

Mara's face went still. “Then we'll have to find them there.”

They remained until the yard lamps came on. A boy emerged from the kitchen with a bucket of scraps and scattered them to several chickens beneath the fence. He turned his head when he passed the creek bed and saw Mara's hand beneath the boards. He did not stop. He continued around the corner as though nothing had happened. When he came back, the stone and paper were gone.

Mara let out a breath. “He got it.”

“How do you know?”

“The boy used to bring messages between houses when the roads were flooded. He knows how to carry something without being seen.”

They moved back toward the quarry path, keeping low. Halfway up the slope, a lantern shone from the main road and a wagon approached. Both women crouched behind a fallen

tree. The wagon stopped at the gate. Doug Barlow climbed down, carrying a bundle of papers. Mary felt her stomach tighten at the sight of the man who'd struck Dean in Hamilton.

Doug spoke with the guard captain for several minutes. They spread the papers on a crate beneath the lamp. Mary could hear only fragments: a date, the word departure, the phrase eastern transfer. Mara listened without moving.

When the wagon left, they waited until its wheels no longer rattled on the road. Then they climbed back through the trees and made for the horses hidden beyond the quarry.

“Did you hear the date?” Mary asked.

“Two nights,” Mara said. “Maybe three. He mentioned a special train.”

“Then we haven't much time.”

“No.”

Mary looked toward the compound lights, dim now through the trees. She thought of Eli trying to get proof before he died, of the journal beneath the stove, and of the men who called this place temporary accommodation. She wanted to tear the gates open that instant. Instead she followed Mara toward the horses, because she had learned that courage was sometimes the discipline to wait until the people one hoped to save could survive the rescue.

The next morning Jonah brought the reply from beneath the fence. Mrs. Talan had written names on the back of a discarded ration list, twenty-seven of them, with small marks beside the sick and the children. She had added the name of a man who had witnessed the Blackwater Creek bridge collapse and the date on which the guards said he would be moved.

Mara spread the paper on the table at the general store. Mary read it carefully, then copied every name into the clean notebook. Dean stood beside the counter and watched without interrupting. He had never known how much work a rescue could require before a single gun was drawn.

“That's them,” Mara said. “These are the people Calvin wants to make disappear.”

Dean touched the page where the children were marked. “Then we'll know who to look for.”

Mary took his hand. “And when we find them, we'll know whom to bring home.”

The list went into the packet of evidence with the journal and the store accounts. It was not enough to arrest Calvin. It was enough to stop the families from becoming numbers in a ledger, at least for those who still had the chance to protect them.

CHAPTER 17

The Men Who Own Hamilton

A week after Eli's funeral, the Hamilton Herald called him a murderer and a railway saboteur. Its report credited a company security patrol with ending a dangerous bandit conspiracy. There was no mention of Red Willow, no mention of the private compound at Carson's Passage, and no mention of the white hat in the coffin above town.

Dean read the article on the boardwalk outside the general store. The type was crooked, the language respectable, and nearly every important fact false.

“Somebody ought to teach the bastard who wrote this to read,” he said.

Neil, hovering beside his stack of papers, looked alarmed. “I didn't write it, Mr. Peters.”

“I know you didn't, kid.”

“I'm only selling them.”

“Then you're innocent of everything except robbery. What's the price?”

“A nickel.”

Dean held up the paper. “For this? Highwaymen used to wear masks.”

Neil smiled nervously. Dean paid him anyway, then saw the bruises still fading along the boy's cheek where Slim Kern had struck him. The smile left Dean's face.

“Did you ever see Barlow out by the station before Eli was killed?”

Neil looked at the street. Railway guards now stood on both corners of the square. Their coats were darker and better kept than the deputies'. They did not bother pretending to answer to Derrick.

“The night before,” Neil whispered. “Porky and Slim were loading rifles into wagons with some men from the eastern

office. It was late. I was taking a bundle to the station and saw them through the freight doors."

"Did you tell the sheriff?"

"I tried. One of those guards said I'd be arrested for spying."

Dean's hands tightened around the newspaper. "You tell Derrick anyway. Tell him I said to listen."

Neil nodded, then leaned closer. "I saw Mr. Douberville's carriage too."

"Where?"

"Going east before dawn. Same road your friend took."

Dean looked up slowly. The boy went pale, thinking he'd said something wrong.

"Thank you," Dean said. "That matters."

He gave Neil a dollar, telling him not to spend it on whiskey. Neil, newly rich, promised nothing. Dean watched the boy return to the boardwalk and considered the terrifying ease with which a man like Calvin could buy an entire account of what had happened.

Inside the sheriff's office, Derrick was learning how that purchase had been made. A pair of men from the county seat had brought warrants bearing a judge's seal. Dean Peters was charged with four murders in the logging woods, assault on company employees, theft of confidential records and sedition against the railway. Mara Wren was named as an agitator. So was a printer named Benjamin Hart, whose newspaper had yet to appear.

Derrick read the papers without offering either man a chair.

"Where's the evidence?" he asked.

"Attached," said the county deputy.

Derrick shuffled the pages. "Statement from Doug Barlow. Statement from Slim Kern. Statement from a railway clerk. That about cover it?"

"The judge has reviewed the matter."

"The judge wasn't there."

"He trusts the company to report accurately."

"Then the judge ought to get out more."

The deputy's expression hardened. "You're directed to arrest these people."

Derrick folded the warrant and placed it on his desk. “I'm directed to investigate. And I'll do it with my own eyes.”

When the men left, Richard Spalding emerged from the adjoining room where he'd been using Derrick's stove to boil instruments. He had heard enough.

“They'll come for your badge,” Richard warned.

“Let 'em.”

Richard gave him a tired smile. “They might take the whole office.”

“Then I'll investigate from the street.”

The doctor started to laugh, but Derrick did not. In two days the sheriff had watched men with private money claim powers his own oath barely allowed. He had jailed thieves, drunkards and a man who had tried to marry a goat on a dare. He had never been asked to arrest a woman because she wanted to keep the place where she was born.

At Red Willow, Mara was doing what the company paper had insisted she could not do: organizing testimony. She sat beneath the blue canvas with a stack of statements while her younger brother, Jonah, repaired a cracked water pump. He had worked for the railway before the fires, first at the engine shed and then on the track crews. Calvin's men called him a deserter. Jonah called it leaving a bad employer.

One by one, survivors told Mara what they remembered. There was an old man who had seen Doug's wagon near the first fire. A woman who had overheard guards discussing the revised boundary before the notice was served. A former rail worker who remembered a payment made to a private security crew on the day Blackwater Creek went silent. Mara recorded each account with care, then asked the speaker to repeat it in front of a second witness.

She did not mistake memory for a perfect instrument. She knew frightened people mixed dates. She knew rumors took on the weight of facts when repeated often enough. That was why she wanted the records, not merely the stories. Her people had told the truth before. Truth, unaccompanied by power, had been easy for Calvin to ignore.

Jonah came in carrying a bucket of clean water. “They're sending a train east next week,” he said.

“Who told you?”

“Man I used to work with at the yard. He says the private office car's being serviced. New locks. New shutters. They're moving the books.”

Mara set down her pen. “And the families?”

“Guards brought another wagon to the compound. Maybe twelve people. Two were children.”

She looked toward the ruined village beyond the canvas. A small girl was building a playhouse from flat stones where a real home had stood. Mara felt her anger come as it always did: not a sudden fire but a pressure in the chest, difficult to lift and impossible to put down.

“Tell Dean,” she said. “And tell him I won't have him charging into that place alone.”

In Hamilton, Mary had spent the afternoon examining her store's old purchasing books. She had kept them because her aunt taught her to keep every receipt, even when paper became scarce. There were entries from Jackson Ward contractors dating back three years. At first they looked like any other business: lamp oil, flour, blasting powder, pick handles, boots. Then she laid Eli's journal beside the entries and began marking dates with a bit of charcoal.

Blackwater Creek: blasting supplies three days before the bridge collapse. Red Willow: lamp oil the week of the first fire. Carson's Gorge: ammunition and freight wagons immediately before the surveyors vanished. The orders had been signed by different clerks but charged against the same company security account.

Mara arrived near evening, bringing statements from the reservation. She stood beside Mary at the counter and looked from the names to the dates.

“That's what we needed,” she said.

“It's not all we need,” Mary replied. “The company could say they bought those things for the crews. They'd be right about some of them.”

“But not about the people who saw the goods used.”

“No. And when the records match the statements...”

Mary left the sentence unfinished. For the first time since the funeral she felt they might be able to do more than mourn Eli. They might prove what he had learned. They might stop the company before another family disappeared.

Mara laid a hand on the old journal. “He was not a simple man, your uncle.”

Mary smiled faintly. “That's one way to describe him.”

“People can do wrong and still try to change. I won't pretend his signature didn't hurt us.”

“I wouldn't ask you to.”

“But he came back with medicine. And he left what he knew. Sometimes those are the beginnings of making something right.”

Mary nodded. The generosity in the words hurt more than an accusation would have.

That evening she found Dean behind the store. He sat on a barrel, cleaning the mud from his boots with a knife. The boards beside him held a cup of coffee gone cold. He had been sleeping poorly, and when he stood the bruise at his temple still made him wince.

“Mara came by,” Mary said. “Jonah's heard they're moving the books next week.”

“Then we've a week to do something foolish.”

“Dean.”

“What?”

“You're not the only person who can do something.”

He looked at her with a stubbornness she recognized from Eli. “These folks will kill you for knowing half what you know.”

“They killed my uncle,” she said. “I'm already involved.”

“I don't want you hurt.”

“That makes two of us. But you don't get to decide how much risk I take.”

Dean opened his mouth, then closed it. He had expected her to be frightened. She was frightened; he could see it. But fear had not made her uncertain. That was a distinction he was only beginning to understand.

“You're right,” he said.

Mary seemed surprised. “What?”

“I said you're right. Don't make me repeat it. Might ruin my reputation.”

She stepped close enough to fix the crooked collar of his shirt. He watched her hands, then her face. The town was quiet around them. At the far end of the alley a horse shook its harness, and somewhere a door slammed.

“You know,” Mary said, “you're considerably nicer when you aren't trying to impress me.”

“When am I trying to impress you?”

“Most of the time.”

Dean laughed. “You make me sound ridiculous.”

“Only because I know you are.”

He reached for her hand. She didn't move away. Their first kiss was tentative, as though both feared it might break if they hurried. Then she leaned into him, and Dean forgot the cold coffee, the warrants, and the bruise at his temple.

When they separated he looked dazed.

“Well,” he said.

Mary smiled. “Well?”

“That was something.”

She laughed. “You're hopeless.”

Dean smiled and looked down. “Eli used to say that.”

The laughter softened. Mary touched his cheek.

“He would have enjoyed making us miserable about this,” she said.

“He'd never shut up.”

She kissed him once more, quickly. They stood together until the last light went from the alley.

Across the square, Slim Kern watched from the station shadows. He had been sent to find out who was gathering records. When he saw Mary and Dean together, he understood he had found something more useful than paperwork.

CHAPTER 18

The Quiet Witness

A man named Samuel Price arrived in Hamilton in the back of a hay wagon. He had once worked the Blackwater Creek bridge crew, and his name appeared in Eli's journal beside a date and the word missing. His hair had gone gray in the last two years. When Mara found him sheltering with relatives farther up the coast, he told her he had no desire to be found again.

“Then why did you come?” she asked him when the wagon reached the abandoned blacksmith shop.

Samuel looked at her with tired eyes. “Because my brother didn't get the choice.”

Dean opened the shop door and helped the man inside. Samuel walked with a limp and carried his right arm close to his body. He sat near the furnace while Mary made tea and Derrick put a notebook on the workbench. Mara stayed beside the door, where Samuel could see her without turning his head.

They were careful with him. Derrick asked his name and his work before he asked about the bridge. Samuel told them he had been employed to lay timber braces beneath the approach and had been paid two dollars a day, a figure that made Eli's five-thousand-dollar bank draft seem obscene. His crew had fourteen men. Most were laborers. Some had signed on knowing the company was unpopular. None had signed on to die.

“The foreman made us pull the bolts,” Samuel said at last. “Said the engineer wanted them inspected. We told him the braces wouldn't stand if the ties came loose.”

“What did he say?” Derrick asked.

“That the line was already closed and no train would use it. Told us to clear out for an hour and come back.”

Samuel's hands tightened around the cup. “My brother stayed to collect our tools. He'd made one of the braces himself. Didn't want it to be blamed if it failed.”

Mary did not move. The room felt suddenly much smaller.

“A wagon came across after we left. Not a train. A wagon with surveyors and two men from the land office. They'd been asking questions about who owned the claims. Somebody cut the warning line across the road. The wagon went onto the bridge, and it fell.”

Samuel looked at the wall. “They called it an accident. The foreman said we'd all be blamed for poor work unless we signed a report. When I wouldn't, Doug Barlow came to my room. He told me my brother's widow would lose the money owed her if I talked.”

“Where'd you go?” Dean asked gently.

“North. Never gave the company a forwarding address. It didn't matter. They found me anyway. A man came with a paper to sign. I signed it. After that they left me alone.”

Derrick wrote carefully, then read the statement back. Samuel corrected two dates and one name. Mara asked whether he remembered who delivered the order. He gave them the foreman's name and added that the instruction had been written on company stationery, with a red seal beneath Calvin's initials. He had kept no copy. He had been too frightened to think like a lawyer.

“Would you testify to it?” Derrick asked.

Samuel stared into his tea. “You can put it down that I will. Whether I can stand up in front of Douberville and say it again is another matter.”

Mara came away from the door and sat beside him. “You'll have others beside you.”

Samuel looked toward her. “What if they go after my sister?”

“Then we'll make sure she's somewhere safe before you speak.”

It was a promise they could not guarantee. Mara knew that, and Samuel knew it. But this was a different kind of promise from Calvin's: it came with people ready to share the risk.

That night Dean went outside with Derrick while Mary and Mara found a place for Samuel to sleep. The alley smelled of forge ash and wet straw. Derrick took off his hat and rubbed his forehead.

“If I'd listened to him when the bridge fell,” he said, “I might've stopped half of what came after.”

“Did he come to you?”

“The company sent a report. I asked questions. The county judge said it had been settled.”

Dean considered him. “You didn't know.”

“I knew the report was thin. I let myself believe a better man had checked it.”

The admission sounded familiar. Eli had said much the same thing. Dean felt anger rise, then fade. He had spent years making his own excuses. He was beginning to understand that a good man and a bad man did not always announce themselves in different voices. Sometimes they were the same man at different moments, and sometimes the only honest thing a person could do was admit the moment he'd chosen wrong.

Derrick leaned against the wall. “We're going to need the original order. If it exists.”

“It exists,” Dean said. “Calvin keeps every scrap that might buy him something later.”

“You sound sure.”

“That's the kind of man he is.”

When Dean returned inside, Samuel was showing Mary a small photograph of his brother. The two men resembled one another except for a scar across Samuel's chin. Mary handed the picture back as though it were made of something fragile. Dean stood in the doorway and realized the case they were building wasn't merely against a businessman. It was for every person whose loss had been treated as an entry in a book.

He took the oilcloth packet of copies from his coat and placed it beside the notebook. On the top page, in Eli's crooked hand, someone had written Blackwater—find the men who worked there.

Dean touched the words with a finger. “Found one, old man,” he whispered.

For the rest of the evening the old shop became a place where people who had been told not to speak came quietly to speak anyway. A railway clerk brought a payroll stub. A woman whose father had disappeared brought a date written on the inside of a Bible. Each story supplied a piece, and no single person had to carry all of it alone.

By midnight Derrick had filled most of his notebook. He closed it with a weary satisfaction. Proof did not make the suffering smaller. But it gave the truth a shape that men like Calvin would have to spend money, effort and lies to break.

CHAPTER 19

The Printer's Lamp

Benjamin Hart had set his first line of type at the age of eleven. His father taught him to keep his fingers clean, his letters sorted and his opinions out of the customer's business. It was sensible advice for a printer who wanted to remain employed. Benjamin followed it for most of his life.

The Jackson Ward Railway changed his mind one advertisement at a time.

At first the company placed ordinary notices: wages for laborers, passenger schedules, warnings about blasting near the road. Then came notices that certain tracts had been purchased and residents must present their deeds to the railway office. Later came announcements that the previous notices had been obeyed, even when Benjamin knew the people had objected. Each announcement was carefully paid for and carefully worded. Benjamin printed them without asking questions, because the shop needed the money.

When the Red Willow fires occurred, the newspaper carried a company's statement describing the destruction as an unfortunate clash between settlers and local residents. He had printed that too, though Mara came into his shop afterward to tell him the account was wrong. Benjamin said he had no reason to doubt an official statement. She asked if he had any reason to believe it. He could not answer.

Now, with Eli's journal before him and the surviving witnesses coming into Hamilton, he faced the sort of decision he'd spent a lifetime avoiding. The town council had advised caution. The company offered him a new printing contract if he would return to commercial work and leave the land dispute alone. His wife warned him that losing the shop would leave them with nothing.

Benjamin read the draft article late one night beneath a gas lamp. Neil was sorting the type, his fingers moving quickly over the cases. Mary had brought a list of purchase records; Mara had brought signed statements; Derrick had supplied the dates on which company guards moved through the district. The evidence did not yet prove every accusation. But it proved that the official reports had omitted facts too important to ignore.

“How do you know which parts to print?” Neil asked.

“Only what we can support,” Benjamin said. “And when we don't know, we say we don't know.”

“Doesn't make much of a headline.”

“Truth isn't always obliged to be exciting.”

Neil looked at the proof. “Wouldn't the company sue us?”

“Very likely.”

“Would they win?”

“Depends whether the judge prefers evidence or company money.”

Neil considered this. “That sounds like a bad arrangement.”

“It is.” Benjamin lifted a line of type and set it into the chase. “But if we never print anything they dislike, we might as well let them write the whole paper.”

Outside, Hamilton settled into night. There was a murmur from the saloon, a whistle from the station and the steady sound of the press gearing into motion. Benjamin remembered the first time he had seen the town square fill with people cheering a train. He had cheered too. The railway had promised trade, medicine, letters, and a way to travel farther than a horse could carry him in a week. Those were real benefits. So were the wages paid to workers who needed them. The difficulty was that Calvin used every benefit as permission to do what came after.

The printer was not against machines. He stood in front of one every day. He was against men who thought a machine could absolve them of what they chose to do with it.

A knock came at the door. Derrick entered carrying a folded list of new names. Neil rose so fast he knocked a case of type sideways, scattering letters across the floor like black seeds.

“Sorry, Sheriff,” the boy said.

Derrick looked at the mess. “You'll be here all night.”

“Probably.”

The sheriff laid the paper on the table. “Samuel Price has signed his statement. So have two former railway clerks. One claims he saw Calvin's secretary order the supplies for Blackwater Creek.”

Benjamin read the names. “Can they prove it?”

“They can swear to what they saw. We'll need the original order for the rest.”

“Then I'll print it as testimony, not as a verdict.”

Derrick nodded. “That's all I ask.”

The three worked until dawn, setting the article line by line. Neil made the headline large enough to be read from across the street. Benjamin made him reduce it twice, then gave in and smiled. When the first proof came from the press, they stood looking at it like men examining something dangerous and alive.

Benjamin's wife arrived with coffee and bread. She read the proof without speaking. When she finished, she set the tray down and put a hand on his shoulder.

“We might lose the shop,” she said.

“I know.”

She looked at the names. “We might lose more than that.”

“I know.”

For a moment he thought she would ask him to stop. Instead she pointed to a date in the second paragraph.

“You've got the year wrong.”

Benjamin stared, then laughed with relief. “God help us. So I have.”

They corrected it. At sunrise the article was ready. In two days the shop would burn and Benjamin would nearly die trying to protect the pages. But the words had already traveled through enough hands that the company could not simply erase them. That, he would later learn, was the advantage of telling the truth in public: even when one copy disappeared, somebody remembered what it said.

CHAPTER 20

The Price of Progress

Calvin Douberville began his morning with a speech about improvement. He delivered it inside his private railway car to a group of investors who had come from the east to see whether their money had been put to work. A polished map occupied the long table. It showed the railway in red ink and the valley in neat pale squares, each square marked by a number that would soon become a price.

“Our line,” Calvin told them, “connects the inland timber to the coast. Freight that once required weeks of wagons will move in days. Mining claims presently inaccessible will become profitable. Hamilton will thrive. Every town along the route will prosper.”

One investor, a narrow man with soft hands, tapped the reservation boundary. “And these claims?”

“Resolved,” Calvin said.

“I've heard there are protests.”

“There are always protests. It is the habit of a changing country to be described as ruined by the people who preferred it unchanged.”

The men laughed politely. Calvin leaned over the map and placed a finger on Red Willow as though it were an inconvenient wrinkle he intended to smooth flat.

He did not mention the families behind the fenced compound. He did not mention the child who had died on the road in a wagon ordered east, or the guard who had quietly resigned after seeing it. There were many things he did not mention, and his investors were willing to consider silence a form of efficiency.

Doug entered near the end of the meeting and handed him a copied page. Calvin read it as the investors discussed expected returns. The page bore a title in bold ink: What Happened at

Red Willow? Beneath it were dates, payroll figures and the name of a dead surveyor.

“Where did you get this?” Calvin asked quietly.

“Printer in town. Boy's been taking notes. Paper's due tomorrow.”

Calvin scanned the numbers. Too exact to be rumor. Somebody had the records.

“Destroy the plates. Collect every page. Find the person who supplied the accounts.”

Doug nodded.

“And Mr. Barlow?”

“Sir?”

“Do not set fire to anything you cannot explain afterward.”

Doug took the warning seriously. He was less successful at following it.

The printing shop stood beside an alley two streets from Hamilton's square. Benjamin Hart had run it for seven years, putting out notices, invoices, advertisements and a weekly newspaper too small to frighten anyone. The proposed article was the most important thing he had printed. He had spent two nights checking the names with Mary, Mara and Neil, and still felt nervous about every line.

Neil was feeding paper into the press when the men came. Slim burst through the front door, followed by guards. Hart managed to hide his proof sheets beneath a loose drawer before a rifle butt struck his shoulder. Neil dove behind a stack of folded newspapers as the men smashed the press, tipped the type cases and tore up the half-finished sheets.

“Where's the copy?” Slim demanded.

Hart tried to answer, but the blow had knocked the breath from him. One guard turned over the desks. Another found the wastebasket full of trial prints and held them up triumphantly.

“That's all of it,” Hart lied.

Slim didn't believe him. He kicked over a lamp. Oil spread across the floor. The flame caught the paper and climbed faster than anyone expected. For an instant even the guards stared at what they had done.

Neil crawled along the back wall, pushed through a window, and landed in a pile of damp boards. He ran without stopping, one shoe half off, until he reached the sheriff's office.

“Sheriff!” he cried, bursting through the door. “They're burning the printer!”

Derrick stood so quickly his chair fell backward. Richard, who was sorting medicine in the adjoining room, came at once with his bag. By the time they reached the shop, flames were coming through the front windows and a crowd had gathered in the street.

Doug stood with two guards blocking the doorway. He was trying to explain to the onlookers that the building had caught fire accidentally during an authorized inspection.

“Move,” Derrick said.

“Private property, Sheriff.”

“There's a man in there.”

“Building's condemned. Dangerous to enter.”

Derrick drew his pistol and aimed it squarely at Doug's chest. “Then you ought to get out of the way.”

The guards looked uncertain. Derrick fired one round into the air, high enough to make several people duck.

“I won't say it again.”

Doug stepped aside. Richard went in with two volunteers and came out dragging Hart between them, coughing and half conscious. Someone brought water. The crowd formed a bucket line, and for a time the street was lit by an awful orange glow against the faces of people who had been told the railroad would make their town better.

Dean watched from the alley with Mary. She had heard the shouting and come running, but he'd caught her before she reached the fire. Her hand tightened around his.

“They're going to kill everyone who knows,” she whispered.

“They're going to try,” he answered.

He watched Derrick standing over Doug, then saw the guards turn away from the sheriff with open contempt. A week before, Dean would have solved the argument with a bullet. Now he thought of Eli's letter, of the names in the journal and

the families who still needed to be found alive. Bullets could stop a man. They could not prove who had paid him.

That night they met in the old blacksmith shop on the north edge of town, where the furnace had been cold since its owner died the previous winter. It was a good hiding place because the railway had offered to buy the property and the widow had refused; the company considered the building already worthless. There were eight people around the table: Dean, Mary, Derrick, Richard, Mara, Jonah, Neil, and Benjamin Hart, whose right arm was in a sling.

Jonah unfolded a diagram of the eastbound train. He had drawn it from memory, marking the locomotive, coal tender, private office carriage, two freight cars and a caboose.

“They're moving the original accounting books,” he said. “Calvin wants them in the eastern office before the investigators from the coast start asking questions.”

“And the prisoners?” Mary asked.

“Behind the office car. Two cars, locked. My friend at the yard says they're loading families from the compound, including people who saw the fires.”

Mara leaned forward. “How many?”

“Twenty, maybe thirty. More if they've taken another wagon.”

“Where are they being taken?”

Jonah hesitated. “The company says a resettlement camp farther inland. I don't believe it.”

He indicated the old crossing at Raven's Gorge. Its bridge had been closed to heavy trains after blasting damaged the western approach. Workers were ordered to repair it, then pulled away to finish the more profitable line. Calvin had arranged for the eastbound special to run despite the warnings.

“Why would he risk his own train?” Derrick asked.

“The private car's got a brake crew and a spare engine waiting before the gorge. He can leave the heavy freight cars on the old grade. If the brakes fail or the couplers are cut, the cars will run down toward the trestle without enough power to stop.”

Mara understood first. “They'll call it an accident.”

“And bury the witnesses with it,” Jonah said.

The room fell silent. Dean studied the map. An ordinary robbery wouldn't save anyone. If he boarded the train and began shooting, the guards could kill the prisoners before he reached them. If they stopped the locomotive on the open track, Calvin's hired men would have a clear field of fire.

“Where does it slow?” Dean asked.

“Devil's Cut. Tight curve before the grade. Not slow enough to climb aboard comfortably.”

“Comfort ain't one of my strong suits.”

Jonah moved his finger to the freight cars. “If you can reach the rear cars and free the prisoners, they can help turn the handbrakes. Then you need to cut the coupling while there's slack. If it works, those cars can stop on the level section before the gorge. We'll be waiting to get the people off.”

“And if it doesn't?”

Jonah looked at him. “Then you've got a very short time to think of something better.”

Dean nodded as though this were useful encouragement. “What about Mary and the ledger?”

Mary answered for herself. “I'll be with Mara and Derrick, helping get the families clear. You'll get the book. We can send it out afterward.”

Dean looked at her, relieved by the plan and ashamed of his relief. She had a right to choose the danger she faced. He had no right to demand that she remain in a room while he took all the risks.

They spent the next day practicing in an abandoned freight car beyond the engine shed, a place Jonah knew the company rarely patrolled. The old mechanic showed Dean how the handbrake worked, how the slack gathered in a coupling when the cars slowed, how a pin that looked loose could seize under strain.

“Pull this only when the cars are nearly level,” Jonah said.

Dean strained at a lever that refused to move. “There's too many damn handles.”

“That's the brake wheel.”

“I know what it is.”

“Then why are you pulling it like a door latch?”

“Because it's making me angry.”

Mary laughed from the rail bed. Dean looked at her with wounded dignity, then heaved again. The pin lifted free and dropped with a metallic clang.

“There!” he said. “See? Easy.”

Jonah regarded him calmly. “Now do it at twenty miles an hour, in the dark, with somebody shooting at you.”

Dean looked at Mary. “I don't like your new friends.”

The training was not a game. Jonah made him repeat the sequence until the moves came from his hands without having to pass through fear. Mara practiced signaling with a lantern. Derrick assembled the small group of riders who would meet the prisoner cars. Neil and Hart prepared copies of the evidence already collected, to be sent from more than one telegraph office so Calvin could not destroy them all.

Each of them carried a part of the plan. It was the first time Dean had ever been involved in something where doing his own job well was not enough. He had to trust people who didn't wear gun belts and some who had every reason not to trust him.

Late that night he sat with Mary on the store's back steps. The town had gone quiet under a low, clear moon. He had an aching shoulder from the training and grease on the cuffs of his only decent shirt. Mary held a cup of tea in both hands.

“Are you scared?” she asked.

Dean thought of the moving freight cars, the prisoners' faces, the narrow trestle over the gorge. “Yes.”

She looked at him, surprised.

“Only an idiot wouldn't be,” he added. “And despite what your uncle said, I ain't a complete idiot.”

“He never called you a complete idiot.”

“That's true. He was always careful to leave room for improvement.”

Mary smiled and leaned against his shoulder. He could feel her trembling, though whether from cold or worry he couldn't tell.

“I don't want to lose you too,” she said.

He started to promise he would return. The words were ready, easy and dishonest. Then he remembered the promises Eli had made when Mary was a girl, and how a man could use kindness to avoid telling the truth.

“I don't know what'll happen,” Dean said. “But I'll do everything I can to come home.”

Mary set her cup aside and held him. The distant whistle of a locomotive came across the valley, a reminder that the railway would not stop because two frightened people wished it would.

They stayed on the steps until the moon passed behind the store roof.

CHAPTER 21

The Bridge

Jonah Wren had always liked machines before he learned to hate the people who owned them. As a boy, he took apart clocks that no longer ticked and tried to make them run with springs cut from old wire. His father told him that a clever pair of hands could keep a family fed, though Mara warned him that clever hands could also build somebody else's fence around their home.

When the Jackson Ward line first came through, Jonah took the engine shed job because it paid cash and because the locomotives seemed like animals made of iron, full of heat and motion. He learned how the fireman fed coal, how the water gauge moved, how the brake valves worked. He kept notebooks of the things older mechanics refused to explain, making sketches after work beneath the lamp in the family house.

Then the new survey arrived. Jonah recognized the altered boundary and went to the shed master. The man told him it was above his station. Jonah went to the foreman. The foreman told him to stop asking questions. By the time the first families were moved, Jonah understood why the company paid him more than the farm work he had left behind: part of the price was expected silence.

He was on the repair crew when the western approach to Raven's Gorge was found unstable. A storm had undercut the outer embankment and left the rails unsupported in places. The crew drove temporary braces beneath the tie ends and marked the line for repairs. Calvin's office ordered the men to finish the new branch first. The old crossing was declared serviceable for light traffic, though Jonah knew the difference between serviceable and safe was about the same as the difference between a promise and its keeping.

He left the railway after Red Willow burned. For a while he repaired farm tools, keeping his head down and pretending not to hear the whistle at night. Mara changed that when she came to him with the brass tag and asked whether a man could identify its warehouse number. He could. He also recognized the name of the freight clerk who issued it. From then on he had been collecting small facts with the patience of a mechanic searching for a fault hidden behind a noise.

On the night before the train rescue, Jonah stood inside the old freight car with a lantern in his hand. Dean was sitting on the edge of the platform, looking down at the coupler they'd spent hours practicing on. His hands were black with grease. Rain had worked through the holes in the roof and made dark circles on the wooden floor.

“You don't trust it,” Jonah said.

“I don't trust any piece of machinery that needs a man to stand between two moving pieces of iron.”

“That's sensible.”

Dean looked up. “First sensible thing you've said all day.”

Jonah set the lantern on a crate. “I want you to understand why the sequence matters. If you try to cut the cars loose before the brakes take hold, they'll run away from you. If you wind one brake too tight while the next is still loose, the wheels will slide and you won't stop. If the coupling stays under tension, the pin won't rise.”

Dean sighed. “I remember.”

“Then tell me.”

“Get the people out of the way. Put a man on each wheel. Turn together when I say. Wait for the slack, then pull the pin.”

Jonah nodded. “Good.”

Dean looked at the narrow gap between the carriages. “And if Calvin's got guards waiting?”

“Then you have to be faster than they are.”

Dean gave him a sour look. “You'd make a terrible preacher.”

Jonah smiled. “You'd make a terrible railway man.”

They worked until the lantern burned low. Then Mara came with bread and a small tin of tea. She watched her brother

explain the braking sequence one last time and noticed the hesitation in Dean's face.

“You keep thinking of fighting a man,” she said.

“That's generally what I'm good at.”

“This isn't a man. It's a job. Do the job, then worry about the fighting.”

Dean considered that. He remembered Eli telling him not to waste two lives on a hopeless charge down a hillside. The old man had been right; courage didn't matter much when it arrived without a plan.

Mara sat on a crate beside him. “You don't have to prove anything to me,” she said.

Dean looked surprised. “I thought you wanted the prisoners out.”

“I do. That's why I want you alive and clearheaded. If you die trying to look brave, I still have the prisoners and another dead man to bury.”

The words came without cruelty. She was accustomed to making decisions that could not afford sentiment. Dean understood her better each time they spoke.

“What made you trust me?” he asked.

“I don't entirely trust you.”

He grinned. “That's encouraging.”

“I trust that you loved Eli. I trust that you want Mary safe. And I trust that you've begun to understand why those things aren't enough if you leave other people behind.”

Dean stared at the rain falling through the roof. “You're good at making a man feel foolish.”

“Then perhaps you should stop giving me so much material.”

The three of them laughed. It was a small sound inside the empty car, surrounded by the smell of rust and old timber. Jonah lifted the lantern again and pointed at the brake wheel.

“One more time.”

Dean groaned. “Christ Almighty.”

“One more.”

He stood, reached for the wheel, and began turning. By the time he finished the motion had settled into his muscles. He

could imagine his hands doing it without his mind having to chase after them. That was the purpose of practice, Jonah said. To leave a little room for thought when fear arrived.

Much later, as they extinguished the lantern, Dean asked how long Jonah had worked for Jackson Ward.

“Two years.”

“You miss it?”

Jonah looked toward the faint outline of the trestle beyond the yard. “I miss what I thought I was building.”

Dean nodded. He understood that feeling. Eli had loved the country and helped draw the lines that wounded it. Jonah had loved engines and watched one company turn them into weapons. Perhaps the work itself was not the crime. Perhaps the crime belonged to the men who decided what the work would do.

Outside, the rain continued. Inside, the freight car was dark. Tomorrow they would have to trust the brake wheels, the people turning them, and one another.

CHAPTER 22

The Bait

Mary had never been good at waiting. As a child she had waited for Eli to return from his work, for her aunt's fever to break, for the mail coach to bring news, for a promise to turn into a fact. The older she grew, the less she believed in patience as a virtue. Sometimes patience was merely what powerful men asked of people while they finished making decisions for them.

That was why she went to the telegraph office with Mara the next afternoon. Benjamin Hart had prepared a detailed statement of the evidence already secured, and a clerk in the town beyond Carson's Passage had agreed to transmit it to a territorial investigator with no company ties. The railway could seize records in Hamilton. It could not easily silence every operator on the line.

The office smelled of damp wool and hot metal. An old telegraph instrument clicked on a desk beside a jar of ink. The operator, a tired woman called Mrs. Lyle, unfolded their documents and read the first page without raising her eyebrows. She had seen enough company business to know when surprise was dangerous.

“I'm going to send this in sections,” she said. “If the line goes dead, we'll have sent something.”

Mara stood by the window. “How long?”

“An hour if it behaves. Longer if the east office interrupts.”

Mary watched the brass key begin to tap. There was something astonishing about the small sound. Words that Calvin could burn on a printed page were traveling into the distance as pulses in a wire, too fast for a horseman to catch.

They had sent two pages when Slim Kern came through the door.

“Well, now,” he said. “Would you look at that.”

Three guards entered behind him. Mara turned at once, hand near the pistol concealed beneath her coat. One guard reached for her. She struck him in the throat and pulled the weapon halfway free. The other guard brought the butt of his rifle down on her forearm. Pain flashed across her face. She dropped the pistol and stumbled back through a side door.

Mary moved toward her. Slim caught her arm and pulled her away.

“Get your hands off me!”

“Easy, Miss Catcher. Mr. Douberville wants a conversation.”

Mara fought her way out into the alley. A shot struck the doorframe above her shoulder. She escaped across the stable yard, clutching her injured arm, while guards shouted behind her. Mary kicked at Slim and tried to break his grip. He twisted her wrist hard enough to bring tears to her eyes.

Mrs. Lyle quietly pushed the partly transmitted pages under her blotter. Slim noticed the instrument and smashed it with the butt of his revolver. Sparks snapped from the broken wire.

“Tell your friend to mind her business,” he said to the operator.

Mary looked back at the desk as they dragged her outside. She hoped enough had gone through. She hoped Mara had escaped. Most of all she hoped Dean would listen to the plan instead of doing what frightened men so often did when someone they loved was threatened.

Calvin received her in the private office car. Its lamps were lit against the afternoon gray, and everything inside appeared designed to make its owner forget he was traveling through a country full of dust. A writing desk stood beneath a polished window. Fine books lined shelves. There was a small decanter of whiskey beside a brass bell.

Calvin rose when she entered. “Miss Catcher. I regret the unpleasantness.”

Mary looked at the guards. “Let Mara go.”

“Your friend has apparently decided to run away. I admire her initiative. Sit, please.”

She remained standing. Calvin smiled and returned to his chair.

“I knew your uncle,” he said. “Rather well, in fact.”

“You murdered him.”

“Your uncle made a series of unfortunate choices. Some of them long before his death.”

He opened a folder and turned it toward her. The first page bore Eli's name and signature. The document altered a line through Red Willow.

“He sold the land,” Calvin said. “He took the money. He later wished to make a spectacle of his conscience.”

Mary looked at the paper. She had seen the same signature in the journal, and it still hurt. “He tried to make it right.”

Calvin gave a small laugh. “An admirable ambition in a man who knows he is about to be caught.”

“He could have taken your money and gone.”

“He did take my money.”

“He came back.”

Calvin studied her. There was a stubbornness in the family he found tiresome. “Where is the journal?”

Mary said nothing.

“The old fool copied records that do not belong to him. I should like them returned.”

“They belong to the people you've been robbing.”

Calvin's pleasant expression became cold. “Miss Catcher, I'm offering you a simple chance to be sensible. You and Mr. Peters could leave this district with enough money to live comfortably. The people you are so concerned with would be resettled. Business would continue.”

“And if we don't?”

He placed the folder down. “Then I suspect Mr. Peters will have to decide which of his heroic ambitions he cares about more.”

Mary realized he had planned something beyond merely frightening them. He knew of the prisoners, the planned rescue, perhaps even the arrangements at Devil's Cut. Someone had been listening. She felt a new fear, not for herself alone but for every person on the train.

At dusk, Dean returned to the general store and found it in disorder. A chair lay broken near the counter, a drawer hung

open, and Mary's apron had been torn from its hook. The room smelled of an unfamiliar man's tobacco.

“Mary?” he called.

No answer.

He went through the storeroom and out the back. Her horse was still in the yard. He came inside again, saw a paper pinned to the counter, and knew before reading it that the trouble had arrived.

Your companion is my guest. Bring Eli Catcher's journal to the eastbound train. Come alone.

It was signed in Calvin's neat hand.

Dean read it twice. The first reading made him cold. The second made him want to break something. He loaded his pistol and went to the sheriff's office so quickly that two men on the boardwalk stepped aside when they saw his face.

Derrick stood as he came in. “What's happened?”

“He's got Mary.”

Dean threw the note on the desk and turned toward the door before the sheriff had finished reading it. Derrick caught his arm.

“Dean. Stop.”

“I've got to get her.”

“We will.”

“He's going to kill her.”

“Maybe. But running onto that train alone won't change it.”

Dean tried to pull free. Derrick didn't release him.

“Listen to me. Mara got away. She told us what happened at the telegraph office. We've still got the plan and the people to carry it out. Calvin wants you angry because angry men do what he expects.”

Dean looked down at the sheriff's hand. For one violent instant he wanted to strike him simply for standing between him and Mary. Then he remembered Eli's letter and the quiet plea written in his crooked hand: Don't let what happened to me turn you into something worse.

He let out the breath he'd been holding.

“All right,” he said. “We do it right.”

Derrick released him. Dean folded Calvin's note and put it in his coat beside Eli's letter. He had never felt so afraid. It made him speak more carefully.

“But we're getting her back.”

At the old blacksmith shop the others gathered again. Mara's arm was bound in a sling. Jonah stood beside the train diagram, making changes. The schedule had been moved forward by several hours; Calvin intended to leave that very night. The private office car would be ahead of the prisoner cars. Guards would patrol the roof and the platforms. There was no time to make a new plan, only to revise the old one.

“Mary's aboard,” Dean said. “Calvin will use her to make me stop.”

Jonah looked at him. “Then you mustn't stop.”

“Easy enough for you to say.”

“It isn't easy. But those families still have to get off. If you can free them, Derrick and Mara will take them to the old grade. After that, you go forward.”

Derrick handed Dean a small folded railway chart, the kind brakemen carried. It marked the grade before Raven's Gorge and the signal lantern position where the rescuers would be waiting.

“I'll get them off,” Dean said. “And I'll get Mary.”

No one told him it could not be done. He was grateful and frightened by their silence.

Outside, the first drops of rain began to strike the roof. The railway whistle sounded from the station. The last departure was approaching.

CHAPTER 23

The Terms of Mercy

Mary discovered that captivity involved a great deal of waiting. The guards brought her into the private railway car at midday and left her near the window while Calvin sent messages, received visitors and gave instructions about the departure. A man who had arranged the disappearance of whole families spent considerable effort locating the right cufflinks for a journey.

The absurdity might have made Mary laugh if she had not been so frightened. She kept her hands in her lap to hide their trembling and watched every movement of the guards. One was a thick-necked man who met her eyes only to make a threat. The other was young, scarcely older than Neil, and looked away whenever Calvin spoke of the prisoners.

“What is your name?” she asked the younger guard when Calvin stepped out.

He glanced toward the door. “Doesn't matter.”

“Everybody's name matters.”

He hesitated. “Walter.”

“Walter, have you seen the people in those freight cars?”

He stared at the floor. “I was told not to speak to you.”

“Then you can listen. There are children in those cars. The company says they're being moved to another settlement. Is that true?”

Walter said nothing. She saw his jaw working.

“Do you have children?” she asked.

“A sister.”

“How old?”

“Fourteen.”

Mary leaned forward. “Would you want her locked up because somebody paid a man to change a line on a map?”

His expression tightened. “Don't make this worse for me.”

“I'm asking because I need to know if you understand what you're doing.”

Walter looked toward the door again. Calvin returned before he could answer. The young guard stood straight, his face blank.

Calvin approached the table and laid down a copy of Eli's confession. He had obtained it from a clerk who had been shown the journal extracts, or perhaps from someone who'd copied them without permission. Mary could not tell. She recognized the clumsy handwriting.

“Your uncle was surprisingly frank,” Calvin observed. “He has made the case against himself as diligently as he tried to make one against me.”

“That's what a confession is.”

“Indeed. Yet it does not seem to have changed your opinion of him.”

“It changed how I see what he did. It didn't change that he loved me.”

Calvin sat across from her. For the first time she saw something like irritation beneath his smooth manners.

“Sentiment makes people unreasonable. Mr. Peters is a good example. He will come here for you even when prudence suggests otherwise. And while he attempts to rescue you, he will be unable to attend to the other passengers.”

“You're going to kill them.”

Calvin raised his eyebrows. “I didn't say that.”

“You didn't have to.”

He rested both hands on the table. “The old crossing is unreliable. An unfortunate accident would be difficult to investigate, especially if the only witnesses were aboard the train.”

Mary stared at him. He had spoken like a man explaining a delay in freight delivery. The coldness of it was more frightening than anger.

“Why tell me?” she asked.

“Because I want Mr. Peters to know the choice. He can save you, or he can indulge this improbable crusade on behalf of strangers. I expect him to choose you. Most men do.”

Mary remembered Eli's voice when he spoke of the land, and Dean's face when he read the letter after the funeral. Calvin believed he could turn love into a lever that moved every other principle out of the way. He had done the same with money and loyalty, making people choose what they cared about most, then charging them for the choice.

“You don't understand him,” she said.

Calvin smiled. “I understand men very well.”

“Then you're about to discover one you misjudged.”

He stood, irritated now. “We shall see.”

When he left, Walter remained by the door. Mary looked at the key on his belt and the small knife hanging beside it. She knew he was afraid. She also knew that fear could make a man cruel or useful, depending on what he did next.

“Walter,” she said quietly. “When the train stops, you'll have a chance to help. It might be the only chance you get.”

He didn't answer. But later, when he brought water, he left the cup close enough that she could reach the sharp iron corner of the table without asking him to move. Her binding was made of cord, tight but not impossibly so. She began rubbing it against the edge each time the guards looked away.

She thought of the night outside the hunting cabin when Dean had promised only to do everything he could to come home. She had asked him not to make promises the world could break. Now she made one to herself: if Dean came aboard, she would not wait helplessly for him to save her. She would do everything she could to help him save the others too.

By evening the office car smelled of lamp oil and steam. A conductor came to report that the train was ready. Calvin placed the red ledger beneath its chain and gave Walter a look that meant the prisoner's silence was to continue.

Mary watched the young guard's hands as he closed the door. They were shaking slightly. She could hear the first sounds of loading from the platform and a child crying somewhere beyond the shutters. She pulled again at the cord around her wrists. One strand loosened against the sharp metal.

It wasn't much. It was a beginning.

CHAPTER 24

The Names in the Freight Cars

The people being loaded at Hamilton Station had been told the eastbound journey would bring them to a new settlement with food and houses. Some believed it because they had grown tired of fighting promises. Others believed nothing but stepped aboard because refusing meant being beaten in front of their children. The guards kept the windows shuttered and separated family groups whenever they thought conversation might turn into resistance.

Mrs. Talan, one of the older women from Red Willow, sat near the back of the first car and counted names under her breath. She had begun the list when the first people were taken from their homes. At first she kept it to remember who needed blankets and medicine. Later it became a record of who had vanished. Names were easier to carry than possessions. She kept them in the order she heard them, as though each might be called at the next stop.

Beside her sat a girl of eleven named Liza, whose father had been taken to the quarry camp. Liza held a wooden bird he had carved before the soldiers came. One wing was slightly longer than the other, and she liked to rub the rough edge with her thumb when she was afraid. Mrs. Talan had been watching the small gesture for three hours.

“Will we see him?” Liza asked.

“I don't know.”

The girl seemed surprised by the answer. Adults had been telling her soon and of course and not to worry for so long that uncertainty sounded like a kind of honesty.

Mrs. Talan adjusted the blanket around her shoulders. “I do know your father wants to find you. And I know your name. That's something I can keep safe.”

Across the car, a man who had once worked at the mill examined the small window with the attention of someone studying a possible exit. He had been taken after refusing to sign an account describing the Blackwater Creek deaths as an accident. He knew the guards were keeping them together because their stories could be tested against one another. That made the car dangerous to Calvin. It also made the people inside dangerous to him, provided they ever reached a place where someone would listen.

Outside, Jonah watched from a shadowed passage beyond the yard. He had slipped into Hamilton before nightfall, wearing a railworker's cap and carrying a tool bag. One of the men on the loading crew recognized him, then turned his face away and said nothing. Another whispered that the prisoners were being sent toward Raven's Gorge, not the advertised settlement. Jonah put the information away like a wrench he would need later.

He spent ten minutes inspecting the switch beyond the freight yard. The relief siding had been cleared. A second engine stood there with its lamps covered. That was how Calvin intended to leave the dangerous train before the condemned crossing: he would transfer himself and his private records at the siding, while the rear cars followed a different movement down the old grade. The crew had been told it was a routine separation. Jonah knew a routine separation did not require two armed guards at the switch.

He took the service road back to the rendezvous, avoiding the company men who patrolled the junction. Mara was waiting with Derrick and the riders. Jonah described what he'd seen, including the relief engine.

“Then Douberville isn't planning to stay with the prisoners,” Mara said.

“No,” Jonah replied. “He intends to leave them behind.”

Derrick checked the time on his pocket watch. The regular freight was due ten minutes behind the special. They would

have one chance at the curve before the traffic on the line made everything impossible.

“Tell Dean,” Derrick said.

Jonah shook his head. “He already knows the danger. If I ride back now, I might miss the train.”

Mara understood. “Then we keep the road clear and do our work when they stop.”

In the freight car, Mrs. Talan heard the first whistle. Children drew closer to their mothers. A man near the door tried to lift the bolt from inside and found it locked. The car jolted, then slowly began to move. Through a crack in the shutter Mrs. Talan saw the lights of Hamilton slide away.

She reached for Liza's hand. “When the door opens,” she said, “you stay with me. Whatever happens.”

The girl nodded. “What if it doesn't open?”

Mrs. Talan considered the question. She had been asked to accept too many impossibilities in the last month, and each time she had discovered that someone could make them possible through cruelty. Perhaps tonight it would be different. She thought of Mara, who had promised people would come, and of the woman Mary who had arrived with medicine and kept returning after there was no reason to hope.

“Then we'll keep our names,” she said. “And when somebody does open it, we'll tell them who we are.”

The wheels gained speed. The little wooden bird moved back and forth in Liza's hand with each joint in the track. Mrs. Talan began to count the names again, quietly enough that the guards outside could not hear.

CHAPTER 25

The Night Train

The train was a thing of light and noise against the wet darkness. Steam curled beneath the station lamps. Porters moved along the platform with collars turned up against the rain, hauling trunks and cases into the forward carriages. The locomotive stood impatiently on the rails, black paint shining, its firebox a pulse of orange behind an iron door.

Calvin had ordered the eastbound special to leave ahead of the regular freight. The official explanation was an urgent inspection of track works beyond Carson's Passage. The unofficial explanation rode in two freight cars near the rear. Armed guards marched families up the steps in small groups. A woman carrying an infant begged to remain with her brother; a guard shoved them apart until another worker intervened. The door slammed. A bolt fell into place.

Mary watched through the office-car window. Her wrists were tied in front of her, and a man with a rifle stood between her and the door. She had spent the afternoon trying to remember every turn of the railway line and every story Jonah had told about the brakes. She knew the train would slow at Devil's Cut. She did not know whether Dean would be there. The thought that he might not come was unbearable; the thought that he might was worse.

Calvin sat at his desk reading a letter, as calm as though the people behind him were ordinary freight. He had changed into a dark traveling coat. The red leather ledger rested beside a brass lamp, locked beneath a short chain. Mary had tried to take it while a guard turned his back, but the chain held and the guard had caught her before she reached the window.

“You're very determined,” Calvin observed without looking up.

“So was my uncle.”

“Your uncle was determined to change his own past. That's a very different sort of ambition.”

She stared at the back of his head. “What are you going to do with those families?”

“They are being transferred to a place where they will no longer interfere with commercial operations.”

“You mean they won't be able to testify.”

Calvin put down the letter. “Miss Catcher, if you wish to survive, you must learn that not every answer is a useful one.”

The engine whistle sounded. Somewhere down the platform a conductor called, “All aboard!” The wheels jolted. Mary felt the car move and knew the night had begun to run away from her.

Outside Hamilton, Dean waited in a stand of alder trees beside the old logging road. Rain had soaked through his coat, and his horse stamped impatiently in the mud. Derrick stood to his left with two townsmen who had agreed to help unload the prisoners once the rear cars stopped. Mara and Jonah waited farther down the grade, where the old road came closest to the railway.

No one spoke much. They had said what needed saying at the blacksmith shop. Dean checked the revolver in his holster, counted his spare cartridges, then found Eli's letter inside his coat. The paper was soft from being unfolded too often. He read only the last line, because that was all he could bear.

The distant whistle came to them through the hills. A glow appeared between the trunks, moving slowly and growing brighter. Dean folded the letter and put it back.

“There's your ride,” Derrick said.

Dean looked over at him. “You ever think about retirement?”

“Every morning.”

“Might consider making it tomorrow.”

Derrick gave a tired smile. “You just get those people off.”

Mara rode up before Dean moved. Her injured arm was bound, but she held her horse steady with the other hand. “Remember their faces,” she said. “If you're tempted to chase Douberville before they're safe, remember why we're here.”

Dean nodded. He had wanted to promise her he wouldn't fail. Instead he said, “I'll do the work.”

The train entered Devil's Cut, where the track curved tightly between two low walls of rock. The engineer eased the throttle. The cars began to sway on their springs. Dean kicked his horse into a gallop along the parallel trail, keeping close enough to the rail bed to feel sparks when the wheels struck joints in the track.

He could hear the thunder of the engine, the screech of metal, the mad, faithful breathing of his horse beneath him. A guard appeared on the caboose platform. Dean ducked below the man's line of sight as the track bent toward him. When the rear rail was nearly beside his shoulder, he stood in the stirrups and leapt.

For a terrible instant he caught nothing. His glove brushed wet iron. Then his fingers closed around the lower rung of the platform ladder, and his feet left the horse. The animal galloped onward into the night, riderless and indignant.

Dean hung above the ties, his coat flapping so hard it threatened to tear him loose. He pulled once, slipped, then

dragged himself onto the bottom step as the guard above turned toward the noise.

“Who—?” the man began.

Dean seized his ankle and pulled. The guard struck the platform and lost his rifle. Dean climbed after him, pinned him against the wall and hit him hard enough to stop the struggle. He left him unconscious in the caboose with his belt tied to a rail.

“Evening,” Dean said, though the man was no longer listening.

He waited until his hands stopped shaking, then took the keys and moved forward through the rain. Ahead, two locked freight cars lurched along the tracks. Somewhere beyond them was the woman he loved, the ledger he needed, and a man who had killed his friend.

Behind him the horse's hooves faded into the forest. There would be no easy way back.

CHAPTER 26

Both

The first freight car smelled of wet blankets, old straw and fear. Dean opened the rear door with a stolen key and found faces turning toward him out of the darkness. A lantern hung from a bracket near the ceiling, swinging with every movement of the train. On the floor sat men and women of different ages, several holding children close. One old man tried to stand and nearly fell because his legs had been cramped too long.

“Who's there?” somebody called.

“Dean Peters,” he answered. “I've come to get you off.”

A woman near the door drew her children closer. “Why should we believe you?”

Dean considered the question. “Well, I ain't shot you yet.”

A nervous laugh passed along the car. It was too thin to count as comfort, but it opened a place where his words could fit.

He told them the plan. They had little time and no choice but to act together. Each car had a handbrake on the end platform. He needed several adults to turn the wheels when he called. The brakes could slow the cars, but only if they worked in unison; too much force on one wheel would seize it before the others caught. The coupling had to be released while the train was slowing and the tension eased. He repeated the order twice until the people closest to the door could explain it back to him.

In the second car he found a Red Willow elder Mara had told him about, a woman called Mrs. Talan. She had witnessed the first forced removals and had refused three offers of money to change her statement. She looked at Dean without gratitude.

“Where is Mara?”

“Waiting down the grade.”

“Is she hurt?”

“Her arm. She'll live.”

The woman's shoulders eased a fraction. “Then tell us what to do.”

He did, showing them the brake wheels and the narrow side ladders. The train's steady movement disguised its speed until Dean looked down through the gap between two cars. Then the ties appeared as a continuous gray blur. He could hear the engine laboring at the front as the grade began to change.

The prisoners were ready when a voice called from above him.

“Mr. Peters!”

Dean looked up. On the roof of the private office carriage ahead stood Calvin Douberville. He held a pistol in one hand and kept Mary close with the other. Two guards were near him, their hats pulled low against the rain. The lamp at the far end of the carriage illuminated Mary's face for an instant. She looked pale but unbroken.

“Dean!” she shouted.

His chest tightened. “Mary!”

Calvin smiled down at him with the patience of a schoolmaster who had caught a pupil cheating. “Astonishing. I had hoped you might be persuadable, but here you are, doing exactly what I expected.”

“Let her go.”

“Your manners are sadly lacking.” Calvin turned the pistol toward Mary's head. Dean stopped where he stood.

Through the trees ahead the moonlit outline of Raven's Gorge began to appear. The railway curved toward its old trestle, where the river ran deep and cold beneath timber worn by years of weather. Far below them there were no lanterns, no rescue boats, no place a passenger could fall and expect to climb out.

Calvin gestured toward the freight cars. “You have a problem, Mr. Peters. I was going to dispose of these unfortunate witnesses by leaving the rear cars on the old grade. With no brakemen, they would have made quite a

spectacle at the gorge. Fortunately for you, they've got an unexpected rescuer."

Dean kept his gaze on Mary. "You planned to kill children."

"An unpleasant consequence of commercial necessity."

"You're insane."

"Perhaps. But I have planned my escape. There's a service siding beyond the cut and a relief engine waiting at the junction. I can leave these cars to do what the laws of nature require."

Dean understood the trap. He had seconds before the route fell away toward the gorge. He could climb forward toward Mary and leave the prisoners to their fate, or he could spend those seconds detaching and braking the cars while Calvin escaped with her. It was the sort of choice Calvin liked to set before other men because it made every possible answer a defeat.

Mary found Dean's eyes. "Save them!" she shouted.

Calvin tightened his grip on her. She winced but did not take back the words.

Dean thought of the people behind the doors: Mrs. Talan, the sleeping children, the man who had spent the last three nights sharing his water with strangers. He thought of Mara in the woods below and of Eli's crooked handwriting. And he looked at Mary, who had chosen to stand against Calvin before Dean was brave enough to say her name properly.

He had no time to make himself noble. He had time only to act.

"No," Dean said.

Calvin tilted his head. "No?"

"I ain't choosing."

He dropped beneath the iron railing as Calvin fired. The bullet struck the upright where his shoulder had been. Dean slid onto the lower step and shouted to the prisoners, "BRAKES! NOW!"

From both cars came the scrape and groan of handbrake wheels turning. The iron shoes bit the wheels. The train shuddered as different parts of it fought against one another. Dean felt the coupling strain and heard the engine pull ahead.

He waited for the moment Jonah had taught him to recognize, when the braking cars began to lose tension against the forward carriage.

Calvin fired again. Sparks leapt from the metal by Dean's hand. He hooked the coupling lever with a curved iron bar and hauled. It would not move. He had thought, while practicing, that he understood what Jonah meant by force. On the moving train, with rain in his eyes and bullets breaking iron around him, force became another thing altogether.

“Come on,” he muttered, and pulled again.

The lever shifted half an inch. Then the train lurched and the pin locked.

From the car behind him a man called, “WE'RE SLOWING!”

Dean saw the wheels turning less quickly against the ties. He had bought them a little time, but the bridge was drawing closer. He braced one boot against the step, threw his weight into the iron hook, and felt the coupling give with a jarring clang.

The separation came suddenly. The forward train surged away while the two prisoner cars, their brakes tightened by desperate hands, continued down the level stretch with a different, slower sound. The gap widened between Dean and the people he had freed. He had only a heartbeat to decide where to put his body.

“Jump!” someone shouted from behind.

He didn't. He lunged forward, caught the last rail of Calvin's private car with both hands, and pulled himself toward it as the iron steps slid beneath his boots. For a moment he hung over the growing space. Then he rolled onto the rear platform, struck his ribs against the railing, and lay gasping while the freed cars diminished behind him.

On the grade below, Mara saw the lantern signal change. The prisoner cars were moving slower now, grinding toward the point where Jonah and Derrick waited beside the track. She urged her horse toward them. Jonah ran beside the first car, reached for its wheel and helped a man inside tighten the brake. Derrick and the townsmen caught the other car. The last wheels stopped well before the trestle. Doors opened, and

people spilled into the rain, some laughing, some weeping, some too stunned to speak. Mara went from face to face until she found Mrs. Talan and clasped her hands.

“Where's Dean?” Mara asked.

The older woman pointed into the dark where the engine's smoke was disappearing. “He went forward.”

Far ahead, Dean pulled himself to his feet on the private car's rear platform. He opened the door and entered a room that smelled of coal smoke, expensive leather and brandy. A guard rose from a chair beside the desk and reached for his gun. Dean struck him with the butt of his revolver before he could fire. Another man appeared at the forward door and shot, breaking a lamp. Dean went behind the desk, returned fire, and forced the guard to flee onto the next platform.

The red ledger lay on the table, still chained to its hook. Dean shot the lock, almost setting the pages alight with the muzzle flash, then caught the book before it slid to the floor. He wrapped it in a piece of oilcloth from a drawer and forced it beneath his coat. Its weight pressed against his chest as though Eli had placed a hand there.

He knew the signatures were inside: Calvin's payments, the hired contractors, the forged boundaries, the truth the old man had died trying to bring into daylight. The book had become as precious as Mary and just as dangerous to carry.

Above him footsteps rattled across the roof. Dean climbed through a side window and hauled himself onto the slick metal. The wind struck him hard enough to steal his breath. Rain cut across his face. Behind him the two prisoner cars had stopped safely, their lamps faint in the distance. Ahead, Calvin was dragging Mary toward the coal tender.

“Calvin!” Dean shouted.

The businessman turned. His hat was gone and his expensive coat whipped about him. Two guards were trying to follow, but one lost his footing when the carriage swayed. The other raised a rifle toward Dean. Dean dropped behind a roof vent as the shot rang out. The bullet tore through the metal. He returned fire from one knee. The guard staggered back and fell onto the platform, out of sight.

Dean ran forward, keeping low. Mary struggled against Calvin's grip. The train was moving faster than he had expected, and the roof pitched under each step. Beyond the tender, the locomotive's chimney poured sparks into the rain.

“Drop your weapon,” Calvin called, pressing the pistol against Mary's cheek.

Dean slowed. He had learned in the last few weeks that men sometimes spoke most confidently when they had the least control. Calvin's voice carried too far and too sharply; his hand shook. The train had passed the service siding, its lamps sliding away into the black, and the relief engine that was meant to collect him had been left behind. Whatever clever arrangement Calvin had made, it no longer worked.

“Let her go,” Dean said.

“You are in no position to negotiate.”

“Neither are you.”

Calvin glanced over his shoulder at the disappearing siding. The realization flashed across his face and vanished beneath anger.

“Your horse thief of a friend should have taught you to quit while you were ahead,” he said.

Dean went still. “Don't talk about him.”

“I remember him begging to be spared.”

“He didn't beg.”

Calvin smiled thinly. “He begged for the girl. A decent sentiment in a man whose conscience arrived twenty years late.”

Dean felt a rage so deep it seemed to lift him out of his own body. He saw Eli falling beneath the trees. He saw Mary's face, the gun close to her skin. He wanted to pull the trigger and end everything that lived behind Calvin's smile.

But Mary was standing there, and the ledger was beneath his coat, and the train was running toward a bridge Jonah had said could not be trusted. His anger would have to wait.

He placed his revolver on the roof. Calvin watched it slide a few inches toward the edge.

“Now step away,” Calvin said.

Dean obeyed one pace. Then, as the carriage lurched around the last curve, he dropped to one knee and drove forward. Calvin fired. The shot missed Dean's head by inches. Dean struck him at the waist. Both men went over the low lip between the office-car roof and the tender, falling into coal dust and iron with a force that knocked the breath from them.

Mary grabbed the railing to keep from falling. She had one hand free; during Calvin's speeches she had been working the rope against the sharp edge of a roof bracket, trading skin for a chance to move. Now she scrambled toward the guard who was reaching for Dean's dropped revolver.

“Stay back!” the man shouted.

She seized an iron lantern from its hook and struck him across the side of the head. He went down against the roof. Mary stood over him for a moment, startled by the ease with which terror could become action. Then she kicked the revolver away from his hand and went toward the tender.

Dean and Calvin struggled among the coal. The older man was stronger than Dean expected and fought without the hesitations of someone accustomed to rules. He drove a knee into Dean's wounded ribs, struck his head against the tender wall, and took a small knife from inside his coat. Dean caught his wrist as the blade came down. The point stopped a hand's breadth from his throat.

Calvin's face was close enough for Dean to see the broken veins along his nose. “You think you're better than me?”

“No,” Dean said through clenched teeth. “Just trying not to be you.”

Calvin pressed harder. The knife moved.

Mary climbed down beside them. She threw the iron lantern at Calvin's shoulder. It struck him, shattered, and sent coal dust into his face. He jerked away. Dean twisted the knife from his hand and drove an elbow into his jaw. Calvin fell back, stunned but breathing.

“Mary!” Dean cried.

She reached him. For a heartbeat they held each other amid the roar of the engine, relief and fear arriving together.

“Are the people safe?” she asked.

Dean nodded toward the rear. “Stopped before the bridge.”

“Then we've got to stop this.” She pointed ahead.

The locomotive was crossing Raven's Gorge. The trestle shuddered beneath its weight. Beyond the far end of the bridge the right rail had torn loose from several rotten sleepers. Jonah had warned them of the damage, but seeing it from the moving tender made the warning a physical thing: a bright jagged gap beyond which the engine could not travel without falling.

The engineer leaned from the cab, shouting that the brake rigging on the forward car was partly jammed. Calvin's men had ordered speed and cut the control link to prevent the rear cars slowing the train. Dean and Mary scrambled to the cab as the wheels hammered over the bridge joints.

“Can you stop her?” Dean shouted.

“I'm trying!” the engineer replied. His face was gray beneath a layer of coal dust. “The tender brake's binding and I've got no room to reverse!”

Dean remembered a dozen hours in Jonah's abandoned freight car, and how one could sometimes solve a problem by refusing to accept the first handle as the only handle. He threw his weight into the handbrake on the tender while Mary climbed back to the private car and spun its wheel. The engineer shut the regulator and worked the locomotive's brake, the three efforts arriving imperfectly but together.

The wheels screamed. The cars shuddered. The cab filled with hot steam from a relief valve, and Dean tasted iron in his mouth. The train crept across the last yards of the trestle. The broken rail came closer. The engineer hauled harder until his knuckles bled.

“More!” Dean yelled.

“There's no more!”

The front wheels rolled toward the gap.

Then the engine stopped with a final violent lurch, close enough to the broken rails that Dean could see the exposed timber beyond the pilot. The world seemed to sway even after the machinery went still. The engineer stared ahead. He began to laugh, quietly at first, then in great helpless bursts.

Dean looked at him. “What in hell's so funny?”

“We're alive,” the man said.

Dean turned toward the gorge, its black river moving far below, and began laughing too. He had never heard such wonderful news.

The laughter ended with a gunshot.

Calvin stood in the cab doorway holding a small pistol he'd kept hidden in his boot. His face was cut and swollen. His once-perfect suit hung in strips, and coal dust filled every fold. He looked like a rich man who had stepped out of a photograph and discovered the world could touch him.

“All this,” he said, raising the pistol toward Dean, “because one old fool couldn't keep his mouth shut.”

Mary was behind him on the narrow platform. Dean saw her lift an iron tool from the floor, but he kept his eyes on Calvin.

“Eli had his faults,” Dean said. “God knows I heard most of 'em. But he was trying to fix what he did.”

“He did nothing but destroy my work.”

“Those homes weren't your work. Those people weren't yours.”

Calvin's gun trembled. “You have no idea what I've lost.”

Mary struck him across the back of the shoulder with the tool. The pistol fired into the ceiling. Dean lunged and drove both men onto the side walkway, where the railing hung above the gorge. Calvin fought back with the last of his strength. For a moment they swayed together at the edge, and Dean felt how easily the world could take another life.

He pushed Calvin against the rail. The old man's shoes scraped on wet metal. Below them the river was white where it passed over stone.

“You killed Eli,” Dean said. “You burned their houses. You killed people who never did you any harm.”

Calvin gripped Dean's sleeve, eyes wide. “Money,” he gasped. “I'll give you money.”

Dean looked at him. The same offer had come to Eli in a clean envelope. Five thousand dollars to make a man forget children, homes, and the years of his own silence. For a moment Dean wanted to throw Calvin over the rail. He wanted

to make the river answer all the things the law might fail to answer.

Then he thought of Mara's records, Mary's testimony, the ledger under his coat, and the people climbing down from the freight cars. If Calvin died here, the company would write another story. It would call him a victim of bandits. The others might escape behind his name.

Dean dragged him back onto the walkway. Calvin collapsed, gasping and shivering. Dean hit him once, hard enough to end the struggle, and stepped away.

Mary came to him. She looked at the unconscious man and then at Dean's shaking hands.

“Why didn't you finish him?” she asked.

Dean looked toward the river. “Because dead men don't testify.”

For a long moment they stood beside the motionless locomotive. Then Mary leaned into him, and he held her. He could feel the fast beat of her heart beneath the soaked fabric of her dress. He had been afraid she would become another loss he had to carry. Now she was warm and alive, and he understood that the choice Calvin had offered had never belonged to him alone. The prisoners had turned the brakes. Mary had fought her guard. Jonah had taught the machinery. Derrick and Mara had waited where they promised. No one had saved everyone. Together, they had saved one another.

Hoofbeats came along the service road. Derrick appeared first, followed by Mara, Jonah and the others. The sheriff looked at the stopped engine, the broken track, the blood on Dean's face and Mary standing beside him, then removed his hat.

“Peters,” he said, “you are a terrible influence on machinery.”

Dean laughed weakly. “She started it.”

Mary punched his shoulder. He yelped and immediately regretted the joke. The others began talking all at once. Someone called for Richard. Someone else said the prisoners were safe. Derrick knelt beside Calvin and snapped irons around his wrists.

Dean reached into his coat and took out the ledger, its oilcloth muddy but unbroken. He put it in Mara's hands. She opened it to a page bearing the Red Willow account number, then slowly closed it again.

“This is it,” she said.

Dean looked at Mary. Her hair was loose and rain-dark. There was blood on her wrist, and she had never looked more beautiful to him.

“Let's go home,” he said.

She nodded. “Together.”

CHAPTER 27

The River Below

The gorge was quieter after the engine stopped than it had been before. The wheels no longer hammered across the trestle, but the river still moved beneath the bridge with the same indifferent force. Steam lifted from the locomotive in slow white bursts. When Dean stood on the narrow walkway and looked down, he could barely see the water through the darkness.

Richard climbed aboard with his medical bag and promptly began shouting at everyone for moving while wounded. Dean submitted to examination only after Derrick threatened to tie him to the locomotive rail. Mary sat on the edge of the tender, letting Richard bind the cuts around her wrists. Her hands ached. She had not realized how much they hurt until there was no longer anything she had to do with them.

Jonah inspected the front of the locomotive with the engineer. The broken rail lay a few feet ahead, its bolts twisted from the sleepers. He crouched beneath the front frame, measuring the distance with his eyes. A few more yards and the engine would have left the track entirely. The knowledge made him feel ill. He had once worked hard to make such machines reliable. Tonight he had trusted strangers to stop one at the last possible moment.

“Was it sabotage?” the engineer asked.

“Partly neglect,” Jonah replied. “Partly deliberate damage. Enough of both to kill a train.”

“Company told us it was safe.”

Jonah looked at the rail. “Companies have a poor habit of describing a thing by what they need it to be.”

The engineer let out a bitter laugh. Then he helped Jonah wedge wooden blocks beneath the wheels so the stopped train

would not roll if a brake slipped. It was a small job, ordinary and necessary. They did it together without exchanging names.

Behind the locomotive, Calvin lay in Derrick's irons beneath a blanket. He had woken long enough to demand a physician and an explanation of why he was being treated like a criminal. Derrick informed him that the doctor was already busy with the people Calvin had endangered. The businessman had gone quiet after that, though whether from pain or disbelief no one could tell.

Dean watched him from the walkway. He had imagined for years that the moment a man like Calvin lay helpless would bring satisfaction. Instead it brought a feeling like exhaustion. The hatred was still there, but it no longer seemed capable of telling him what to do next. He remembered Eli asking whether men could become better than the things they'd done. The answer did not arrive in a flash. It came as a responsibility to keep making the next choice well.

Mara climbed up beside him. Her arm was still in a sling, and her face was streaked with mud. She was smiling, but there was little triumph in it.

“The prisoners are safe,” she said. “All of them we counted.”

“Anybody hurt?”

“Scrapes, bruises. One man broke an ankle climbing down. They could use the doctor when he's finished with you.”

Dean looked at the oilcloth-wrapped ledger beside her. “You have it?”

“Yes.”

“Then take it somewhere that can't burn.”

Mara rested a hand on the book. “We'll take copies to three places. The original goes with Derrick and two witnesses. No one man will carry the whole case.”

Dean smiled. “You sound like Eli.”

“I think he learned some of it from me.”

He laughed, a small tired sound that surprised him. “He probably did.”

For a while they stood looking toward the stopped prisoner cars, their lamps faint in the trees beyond the curve. Mara could see movement around the doors where the rescued

families were being helped onto wagons. Some would go to Red Willow that night. Others would remain under guard in Hamilton until the inquiry could take their testimony. It was not the kind of homecoming that appeared in a railway advertisement, but it was a beginning.

Mary came up beside Dean and took his arm. He winced, then tried to hide it. She noticed and laughed softly.

“You know,” she said, “I was beginning to think you'd go through every bridge in the territory just to avoid admitting you need a rest.”

“I've had a very difficult evening.”

“So have I.”

“I noticed.”

She looked at him. The words that might have been said—about the moment Calvin held a gun to her head, about Dean leaping between the moving cars, about what they had nearly lost—were too large for the cold walkway. She rested her forehead against his, and that was enough.

Down below, the river moved through the gorge. The old trestle groaned as the wind shifted, and the locomotive settled against its blocks with a faint metallic sigh. Jonah called that the track would have to remain closed until a proper crew inspected it. Derrick agreed, adding that this time the company would not be allowed to declare the damage safe merely because a schedule demanded it.

They began the slow walk down the service road toward the horses. Dean leaned on Mary's shoulder, and she leaned on him when the ground turned slippery. Neither pretended the other was unhurt. Behind them the engine stood silent on the bridge, all its power useless without the hands of people willing to guide it.

At the turn in the road, Dean looked back once. He could see Calvin's guarded wagon moving toward Hamilton and the first dawn light gathering over the trees. The old man's white hat would be waiting at the grave when they got home. Dean thought of it, then of the people in the wagons ahead, and turned toward the rising light.

CHAPTER 28

The Dawn Papers

By the time they brought Calvin back to Hamilton, the night had become a pale gray morning. He sat between two deputies in Derrick's wagon, wrists bound and his expensive clothing wet with rain. A crowd had already gathered at the station. Some had heard that the special train had broken down near Raven's Gorge. Others had heard a version in which Dean single-handedly fought fifty men and stopped the engine with his bare hands. Neil was selling both accounts for the price of a newspaper that had not yet been printed.

Derrick wanted to laugh at the rumors. He wanted to sleep more. Most of all he wanted to get the prisoner behind a locked door before Calvin remembered how many people in town owed him money.

Mary walked beside the wagon with Dean, who had refused Richard's invitation to return to the surgery until he saw the ledger put somewhere safe. Mara carried it in both hands, wrapped in its oilcloth covering. Her brother Jonah walked beside her, inspecting the broken binding with the attention of a mechanic who knew how easily a valuable thing could be damaged.

At the sheriff's office they laid out the book beneath two lamps. Derrick sent for Mrs. Lyle, Benjamin Hart and the county clerk, a man who had not yet decided which side of the law he intended to be on. He asked each witness to observe the seals and the condition of the pages before anyone read or copied them. The clerk's reluctance disappeared when Mara opened the book to the Red Willow entries and showed him the same numbers that had appeared in the altered land claims.

“Are these original?” the clerk asked.

“That's what we're asking you to record,” Mara replied.

He looked at her, then at the sheriff, then lowered his eyes to the page. “Yes. Original register, company seal, binding intact except for the lock. I'll put it in writing.”

Dean leaned against the wall and watched the man write. It had taken gunfire, a funeral and a train nearly going into a gorge to make the fellow move his pen across a sheet of paper. There was something discouraging about that. There was also, in the slow scratching of the nib, a satisfaction Dean hadn't expected.

The next hours were devoted to copying. Richard cleaned Dean's wounds in a corner, complaining while he worked. Mary and Mara read entries aloud. Mrs. Lyle prepared a series of messages to independent offices beyond the county, each bearing dates and figures that could be compared with the physical book if it vanished. Hart set type for a special edition naming the witnesses who had survived. He did not print statements they had not approved.

At noon Calvin demanded to see his lawyer. Derrick allowed it. The businessman sat inside the holding cell, still carrying himself as though the office were his. He spoke about malicious prosecution, theft of property and the financial harm the arrests would cause the town. Derrick listened without interrupting.

“You understand what this will cost Hamilton?” Calvin asked.

“Some folks around here have already done the arithmetic.”

Calvin's eyes narrowed. “Men like Peters cannot be trusted. He's a wanted criminal.”

“Possibly,” Derrick said. “He'll have his own questions to answer.”

“And the woman from Red Willow? She has an interest in the claims.”

“She does. So does everybody you drove off the land.”

Calvin straightened. “You think this makes you a hero?”

Derrick leaned against the door. “No. I think it means I've finally started doing my job.”

He left Calvin there and went back to the records room. In the afternoon a company attorney arrived with papers

demanding the immediate return of the ledger. Derrick asked the man to identify its contents for the record. The attorney declined. The sheriff informed him that it would remain evidence in an active investigation. The man threatened to appeal. Derrick told him to bring a pen and make a proper request.

That evening the first rescued families reached Hamilton in wagons. The two freight cars remained on the safe section of track; Jonah would arrange to move them the following morning under the supervision of independent railroad workers. The rescued passengers climbed down into the station yard, exhausted and uncertain. Some were met by relatives. Others stood waiting, holding bags that contained everything they had left.

Mara found Mrs. Talan and Liza near the water trough. The older woman held the girl's hand tightly. When Mara told them they were safe, Mrs. Talan looked at her for a long time before the words seemed to make sense.

“You kept your promise,” she said.

“We all worked to,” Mara answered.

Liza showed her the carved bird, explaining that one wing was longer because her father had run out of good wood. Mara knelt and inspected it gravely, then told the girl she knew where several of the missing quarry workers had been sent and would help her search for him. The girl nodded and took her hand.

Dean watched the reunion from the far side of the yard. He had seen bodies fall, buildings burn and a man nearly drown in his own greed. He had thought the end of the fight would feel like the last shot of a gun. Instead it felt like this: people climbing down from a dirty freight car into a town that didn't yet know what to do with them, and a woman promising a child help that would require more work tomorrow.

Mary came beside him. “Richard wants you back in bed.”

“I'm considering it.”

“That's the most encouragement he'll get.”

Dean smiled. She took his hand, and he rested his forehead briefly against her hair. He was tired enough to sleep standing

up. The ledger was in safekeeping. Calvin was behind bars. The rescue had succeeded. But there were names yet to find and wounds that could not be dressed in Richard's surgery.

“The old man would have enjoyed this,” Dean said.

Mary looked at the crowd. “He would have made a dreadful speech.”

“Longest you'd ever heard.”

“And then he'd have tried to charge everyone for it.”

Dean laughed. “Absolutely.”

They stood together until evening, when the depot lamps came on and the first independent telegraph reply arrived. The investigator from the coast had received the evidence. He would come with deputies and witnesses of his own. The case would not be confined to Hamilton, where Calvin had long kept the doors closed.

Mary read the message twice, then handed it to Mara. No one cheered. The work ahead was too large, and the years behind it too painful, for a victory to fit inside one sheet of paper. But for the first time the paper carried news they had written themselves.

CHAPTER 29

So Long, Partner

In the days that followed, the arrests spread beyond Calvin’s cell. Doug Barlow tried to leave town on a freight train and was pulled from a baggage compartment after Neil saw him buying a ticket under another name. Slim Kern disappeared for four days, then surrendered when he learned the territorial marshal had warrants for the men who had burned Benjamin Hart's shop.

The ledger survived every attempt to discredit it. Calvin's signature appeared beside payments made to contractors before the Red Willow fires. The same dates matched Mary's store accounts, Mara's statements and the records Mrs. Lyle had managed to send before Slim smashed her telegraph key. Survivors identified the men who took their families. Former railway employees, emboldened by the arrests, came forward with more documents.

The legal process moved more slowly than grief. Calvin hired counsel. Company agents claimed the signatures were forged, that the payments were routine, that the disasters were tragic accidents. They spoke of progress and lawful authority. They spoke less readily when an investigator produced matching account entries from three separate offices and a shipping manifest bearing Calvin's own seal.

Derrick watched the proceedings from the back of the county courtroom. Dean sat beside Mary, his ribs still bound, while Mara listened with an attention so absolute that the judge eventually stopped glancing at her. When Calvin was called to answer a question about the forced removals, he looked across the room at the people from Red Willow. For the first time Dean saw a trace of uncertainty in the man's face. It was not remorse. It was the realization that the people he'd

treated as quantities had names, memories and a willingness to use them.

The court ordered the disputed removals halted while the territorial inquiry continued. Several land officers were suspended. The damaged Raven's Gorge trestle was closed. The railway's investors began distancing themselves from Calvin, claiming ignorance with an enthusiasm that impressed no one.

Not everything was fixed. The rail line remained. Some homes had burned beyond repair. Some families had moved far away and would not return. No court could restore the dead, and the timber already cut would not stand again in their lifetimes. Mara refused to let the town describe the inquiry as a victory large enough to erase what had happened.

At Red Willow she and Jonah helped mark the restored boundary with new stakes. The work was supervised by an independent surveyor and witnessed by families who had lived there before the railway arrived. They used the old agreements, not Calvin's maps. When Jonah pulled up the last of the false stakes, Mara set it aside rather than throwing it away.

“Keep it,” she said. “So nobody gets to say it never happened.”

Jonah looked toward the ruined houses, where builders were raising new frames. “We've got a long way to go.”

“Yeah,” Mara said. “But we're still here.”

In Hamilton, the printing shop reopened in a borrowed storeroom. Neil sold the first new issue of the Herald's rival paper before breakfast. It carried a photograph of the damaged trestle, a report on the inquiry, and the names of those missing from Red Willow. Hart had insisted on printing those names in full, even when it meant leaving less room for the advertisements that kept the press running.

Richard Spalding examined Dean one last time in the surgery. He loosened the bandage around the younger man's ribs, frowned at the healing bruise and announced that most men would not have survived such treatment of their bodies.

“Guess I'm special,” Dean said.

“Special isn't the word I'd use.”

“You've a cruel bedside manner, Doc.”

“I find it helps people avoid returning.”

Mary appeared at the door carrying a basket of food. She listened to their argument with the calm pleasure of someone who had finally become accustomed to hearing Dean complain. The doctor took the basket, removed a piece of bread and informed Dean that his bills could be paid by carrying firewood for the hospital once he was able. Dean said it would be a privilege. Richard gave him a look that suggested he would hold him to it.

Outside the sheriff's office, Derrick handed Dean a written statement acknowledging his role in the prisoners' rescue. Dean read it with some suspicion.

“Am I under arrest?” he asked.

“Not today.”

“Tomorrow?”

“That depends. You planning to steal anybody's horse?”

“Only if they're charging too much.”

Derrick smiled, then became serious. “There's still the matter of those four men at the logging camp. And the other things you did before you came here. I can't make it all disappear because you helped us now.”

Dean folded the paper. “I know.”

“I've written down what I witnessed. So have the people you saved. You'll have to answer questions sooner or later.”

“Fair enough.”

Derrick studied him. A few weeks earlier the answer would have surprised him. Now it felt right. “Where will you go?”

“West, I think. Somewhere with work and no railway company eager to hire me.”

“That's a narrow field.”

Dean laughed. “I've always liked a challenge.”

Mary was waiting near the livery stable with two saddled horses and a small trunk. She had sold her share of the general store to the clerk who'd worked beside her for years, keeping enough to start again somewhere quieter. She had told Dean she wasn't leaving because he asked. She was leaving because

she wanted to see what might happen if she chose a road for herself.

Before they rode, she went with Dean to Eli's grave. The morning was bright after days of rain. They took the trail through the redwoods, past moss-covered logs and the first stumps the partners had found together. The same crow—or one very like it—stood on a pale circle of fresh-cut wood, watching the horses pass.

They left the animals near a fallen cedar and walked the final stretch. Eli's grave lay beneath a tall tree, where the roots made a dry rise above the path. Derrick had helped set a simple wooden marker. Mary had chosen its words:

ELI CATCHER A friend. A partner. A man who tried to make things right.

Dean knelt beside the grave. He carried two small cups and a bottle of whiskey. Eli would have complained about the size of the cups, so Dean filled them generously. He placed one beside the marker and took a drink from the other.

“Well, old man,” he said. “Sure made a hell of a mess, didn't ya?”

Mary remained a little way down the trail. She knew the two men had their own kind of conversation, and she would let it finish.

“Calvin's locked up. Mary tells me the town's better off without him. Doctor says I'm an idiot, but I reckon he was going to say that no matter what happened.”

Dean looked at the white hat in his hands. He had brushed the dirt from it, but there was still a stain along the brim that would never quite come out. Eli had worn it through rain, gunfire, whiskey and more arguments than Dean could count. Dean felt its weight and thought how a man might leave behind so little and so much at once.

“Those families,” he said softly. “They're coming home. Not all of 'em. Not the way it was. But some of 'em. Mara says they're putting up houses, and Jonah's getting the pump working.”

He placed the hat on the wooden marker. A breeze lifted its brim before it settled.

“Wish you'd seen it.”

He took the letter from his coat. The edges were worn where he'd folded and unfolded it. He read one line, then another, smiling despite the ache in his chest.

“World's second-best horse thief,” he said. “You old bastard.”

He laughed quietly. A bird called above the clearing. For a moment he could imagine Eli answering, saying he had been first and would always be first, even if he'd once stolen the wrong horse.

Dean stood and removed his black hat. He held it for a long time, considering whether to leave it beside the white one. The man who'd worn it into Hamilton had done things he couldn't undo. He would have to answer for some of them, and there would be days when the road ahead looked no better than the one behind. He could not lay his life on a grave and call it finished.

He put the hat back on.

“So long, Partner,” he said.

Mary waited by the horses, her hair loose beneath a simple traveling hat. When Dean came down the trail she took his hand and squeezed it without speaking.

“Ready?” she asked.

“Yeah.”

“Where to?”

Dean looked west, where the forest opened toward the coast and a road that was not on any of Calvin's maps.

“Somewhere they could use a couple honest folks.”

Mary raised an eyebrow. “Honest?”

“One honest woman and one reasonably trustworthy criminal.”

“That sounds more accurate.”

They mounted. As they started down the trail, Mary turned toward him.

“Did Uncle Eli really try to steal your horse?”

“Absolutely.”

“Why?”

Dean thought of the old man in the woods, his white hat tipped back, his laugh rising above all the noise in the world.

“Well,” Dean said, “I reckon I might've stolen his first.”

Mary's laugh followed them beneath the trees. Dean laughed with her. They rode on together, small figures under a roof of redwood boughs that had stood before the railway and would stand long after the men who built it were gone.

A crow lifted from the stump and flew toward the light.

THE END